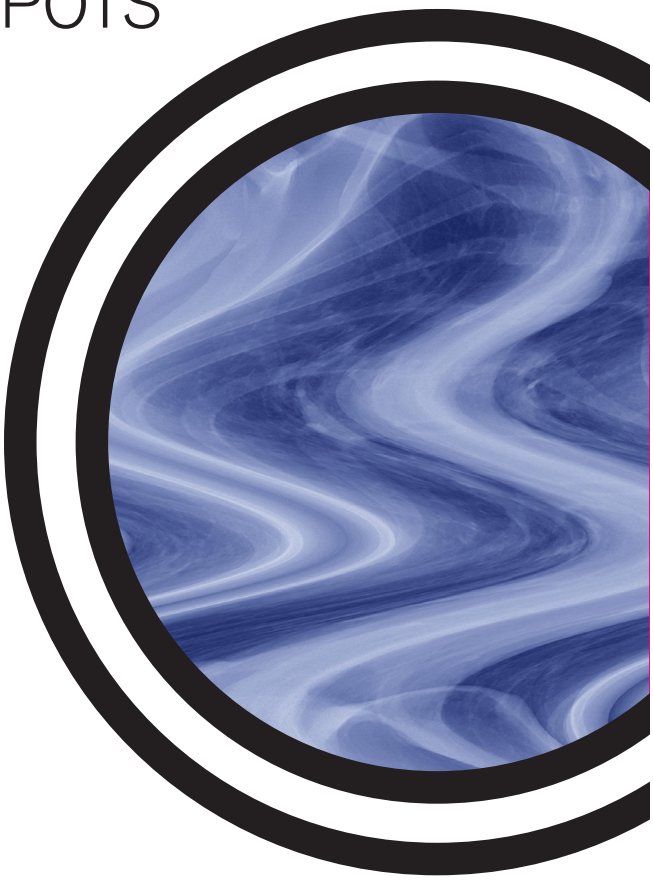
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BLIND SPOTS



transgender cancer patients fight their disease and our medical system

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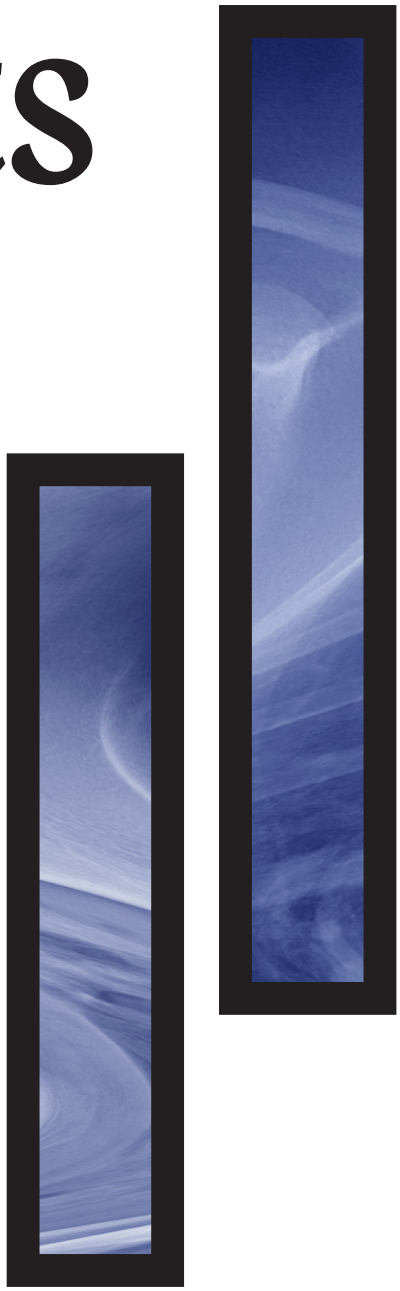
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Monumental Worries

A Rift over Land Rights in the Wild(ish) West



IMAGES COURTESY OF **JANET WILCOX**

BY **THOMAS C. MARTIN**

IF YOU WERE TO DRIVE from New Haven to San Juan County, Utah, it would take you more than a day and a half, not including stops. Even if you were to fly into Salt Lake City International Airport, almost six hours of driving would separate Utah's bustling urban core from your remote destination. The largest county in Utah, San Juan spans diagonally across the state's southeastern corner like a dog-eared page laid flat in a long-forgotten book.

In the heart of San Juan, a landscape defined by its rust-toned earth and sparse vegetation, a surprisingly dense forest endures. In satellite images, this stretch of trees looks like a dark green stain. Two parallel rocky buttes ascend from this verdant blotch, so conspicuous and prototypical that their names in each of the region's indigenous languages all share the same English translation: Bears Ears.

Few people outside of Utah and the surrounding tribal nations had heard of Bears Ears until three years ago. In October of 2015, the Bears Ears Inter-Tribal Coalition, a partnership of representatives from five local Native American nations, approached then-President Barack Obama with a proposal calling for the buttes and the surrounding 1.9 million acres of land controlled by the Bureau of Land Management to be proclaimed a national monument. The area is rich in paleontological resources, Native American petroglyphs, cliff dwellings, and artifacts. The Coalition's proposal cited the "deplorable acts" of looting and grave robbery as some of the chief motivations for protecting the land, stating that looters "defile the past and wound the present, which for us is so directly connected to the past." The Coalition also wanted to limit future development on the land, including uranium mining, which the proposal states has previously resulted in "many illnesses and deaths of Indian people.".

In December 2016, Obama accepted a modified plan that included approximately 1.3 million acres, two-thirds of the area requested by the original proposal. Overnight, Bears Ears became both a national monument and a political flashpoint. To Republicans, the designation was a desperate land grab in the twilight of Obama's presidency, an egregious case of federal overreach. But to Democrats, the monument, as the first to be governed in part by an inter-tribal commission, was a resounding victory for conservation and indigenous land rights.

If it was a victory, it was short-lived. Last December, President Donald Trump cleaved Bears Ears into two much smaller monuments: Indian Creek and Shash Jáa. The cuts amount to a drastic 85 percent reduction in the monument's acreage. (The rest of the land will remain under the care of the Bureau of Land Management.) This decision is being challenged in several lawsuits, and Trump has ensured that this rugged expanse of terrain will linger in the national dialogue about public lands for the foreseeable future.

But how did local residents react to the Bears Ears designation? *The Politic* interviewed several

San Juan spans diagonally across the state's southeastern corner like a dog-eared page laid flat in a long-forgotten book.

Utahns, all but one from the San Juan area. Efforts were made to contact Native American residents of San Juan County, but none was successful.

The backgrounds of those *The Politic* interviewed vary from mortgage lender to fifth-generation rancher, newspaper publisher to retired schoolteacher, and county commissioner to Yale sophomore. Most were opposed to the initial monument designation, but not necessarily for the same reasons.

*

THE FIRST TIME I CALLED Bruce Adams, the cattleman who chairs San Juan County's Board of Commissioners, I had a hard time getting a hold of him. After an awkward exchange with his receptionist and several dropped calls, I finally reached him on his cellphone. Adams' family has lived in San Juan County and raised cattle there for five generations. Part of his inheritance, it seems, is a deep fondness for stewardship.

"We learned how to be respectful around the land," Adams told me.

As a commissioner, Adams is fiercely defensive of his constituents' character. He maintained that the looters ransacking Native American sites near Bears Ears were not San Juan locals, but rather out-of-towners seeking to cash in on county and tribal resources.

But Adams also faces his own challenges related to Bears Ears. Ranchers like him rely heavily on public lands for grazing, and while the initial monument designation did not explicitly forbid grazing, He had reason to be suspicious of future policy changes.

As ranchers near Grand Staircase-Escalante, a monument about 100 miles west of Bears Ears, told *St. George News*, that monument's creation in 1996 did not technically ban grazing—but restrictions on temporary land modifications made grazing much less efficient and less profitable. Adams was concerned that history might repeat itself with Bears Ears.

Ranchers are not the only San Juan residents with strong opinions about the monument. Janet Wilcox and her husband, both transplants from Idaho, relocated to the San Juan area in 1970. Wilcox and her family adore the county's harsh natural beauty, but all but one of Wilcox's eight children have moved away in search of stable employment.

The controversy surrounding the national monument designation, which Wilcox opposed, has raised the profile of Bears Ears and will likely attract more tourists in the future. For Wilcox and many other San Juan residents, the nearby city of Moab, Utah provides a cautionary tale.

Moab serves as the gateway to both Arches and Canyonlands National Parks. Its proximity to those recreational focal points has made the local economy heavily dependent on the seasonal tourism, hotel, and restaurant industries, restricting long-term job opportunities for the city's more than 5,000 residents.

"We do not want to be another Moab!" Wilcox told *The Politic* in an email.

Bill Boyle, a San Juan resident for the last forty years, echoed Wilcox's sentiments. Boyle serves as the editor and publisher of the local newspaper, *The San Juan Record*, whose website header speaks to the cultural scene of the county itself: In a detailed drawing, a cowboy rides a horse in the foreground, while behind him is a large yet faded indigenous petroglyph. It is almost too on-the-nose.

When I asked him about his relationship with the land in Bears Ears, Boyle spoke with reverence. "It's everything. It's the background to my life,

"The land is being loved to death."



and it's where I go to seek solace," he told me. But he thought the monument designation was counterproductive.

Like Wilcox, Boyle sees a sudden ingress of out-of-state visitors as bringing more harm than good. While he agreed that the land should be open to the wider public, he argued that county resources are being spent on the consequences of increased visitation, such as searching for lost tourists. He also expressed concerns about the impact of uninformed visitors—who may not recognize how sacred the area is to the region's tribal nations—on Bears Ears' natural allure.

"The land is being loved to death," he said.

For mortgage lender Britt Barton, tourism is a mixed bag. Barton is the manager of Primary Residential Mortgage, Inc.'s Blanding, Utah division. He said he would enjoy seeing more tourism in San Juan County, as a healthier tourist economy would attract more homebuyers. But he also believes a diversified economy is leagues better than one dependent only on outside visitors.

"We've seen challenges, particularly in Grand County [which includes Moab] with such a one-sided economy when it comes to tourism, that the real estate market has priced itself out," Barton told *The Politic* in an interview.

"There are plenty of jobs to be had, but no one can afford to live there," he said.

Barton grew up in San Juan County and became familiar with Bears Ears as a Boy Scout. He often went hunting and horseback riding there with his father, and his family hosted reunions on Elk Ridge, an area Trump removed from the monument in his December announcement. Barton worries that even if the size reduction stands up in court, the monument designation will still bring harm to the pristine land.

"By putting [Bears Ears] on the map…[monument supporters] create the very problem they were trying to protect it from, which is damage from overuse," Barton said.

Not all Utahns were opposed to the initial monument designation. Marcelina Kubica '20, has lived in Ogden, just north of Salt Lake City, for almost her entire life, and her family often travels in and around the Bears Ears area to explore the arresting terrain. Her love for the landscape is palpable.

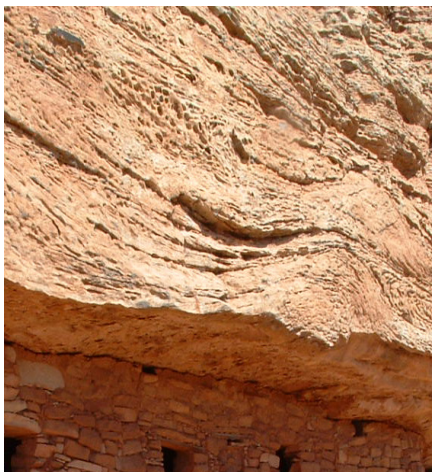
"[The land is] part of who I am and who I want to be. Part of my story and the reason I love living," she told *The Politic* in an email.

An avid hiker and backpacker, Kubica's relationship with the land is purely recreational. She said she wants to "engage with the beautiful environment throughout [her] life," so she was disheartened by the Trump administration's cuts to Bears Ears. She hopes that, even without the formal designation, the land will continue to be responsibly maintained by San Juan locals.

She also believes that recreation should not be the focus of the dialogue surrounding public land use in Utah.

"I believe the central point of the conversation should be recognizing the history of these public lands and the people who lived on/with them long before the U.S. government showed up," she said, referring to the importance of Bears Ears to the Navajo, Hopi, Zuni, and Ute tribes.

Kubica thinks that non-Utahns often misunderstand the history behind Bears Ears and other public lands. Monument advocates and opponents have struggled with questions of Native American land claims, the ability of public lands to protect heritage, and the economic ramifications of conservation. These questions extend two thousands miles to Yale's own campus, which once was part of the Quiripi tribes' territory. The fight over Bears Ears may seem remote to us, but the question of how native land and history should be preserved could not be any closer.





Angola's Nearly Fallen Eden

The Battle to Resurrect a Nation's Wildlife

BY **PETER ROTHPLETZ**

BRIAN HUNTLEY CAN'T help but remember his first conservation expedition to Angola in September 1971. He and his partners—hired as state ecologists—were stationed in an abandoned restaurant that overlooked the Cuanza floodplains. Every morning, he would look out from the building's veranda and watch herds of elephant, red buffalo, and bushbuck graze on the miles of swamp grasses below.

These vistas don't exist anymore. Instead, in Huntley's most recent book, *Wildlife at War in Angola,* the South African biodiversity consultant solemnly describes a landscape teetering on the brink of ecological ruin—a nearly fallen Eden. Rusting tanks and live landmines litter the bush, serving as grave markers for the species that have been hunted to local extinction. The country is at a crossroads, grappling with competing calls to preserve cultural tradition, intensify economic development, and save the few animals that remain within its borders.

"Since 1975, most, if not all populations of large mammals have been severely reduced, if not eliminated," Huntley explained in an advance copy of his book provided to *The Politic.* "Wholesale slaughter of elephant, rhino, eland, roan, oryx, springbok, zebra, bushbuck, reedbuck, lechwe and many other species occurred in all parks and reserves."

Huntley is not alone in noting Angola's decimated wildlife. But decades of proxy war and civil conflict have all but prevented conservation groups from accurately assessing conditions on the ground. That is, until recently. Last July, the *Associated Press* published a story detailing the conclusions of a pair of research surveys launched by *National Geographic* and Panthera, a New York-based big cat preservation group. Their findings confirmed Huntley's fears.

"The common ungulates are largely thinned out," Dr. Paul Funston, Panthera's senior director, stated grimly in an interview with *The Politic.* "All the wildebeest, all the buffalo are almost non-existent, and once those prey animals disappear, the lions and hyenas tend to blink out quite quickly. The situation is not good."

IT IS DIFFICULT TO CHRONICLE how Angola found itself in its current plight, but most explanations start with the country's long history of exploitation—500 years as a slave state, a penal colony, and an agricultural outpost for the Portuguese.

"The colonialists brought a hunting culture with them to Angola," Funston asserted, "so what we see today is first a legacy of killing wildlife for sport." White settlers viewed the nation's fauna as little more than a source of recreation, while subjugated, native peoples increasingly turned to poaching for basic subsistence. This model persisted for centuries, but the environmental abuse didn't devolve into a full-blown crisis until much later.

Shortly after securing independence from Portugal in 1971, the southwest African state slipped into a power struggle between its two former liberation blocs: the People's Movement for the Liberation of Angola (MPLA) and the National Union for the Total Independence of Angola (UNITA). Despite a shared mission to end colonial rule, the organizations found themselves divided along ethnic lines. The former faction drew its support from the Mbundu and the Mestiqos, who comprised the country's bourgeoisie, while the latter was buttressed by the Ovimbundu, who tended to be geographically fragmented but united by a right-wing militancy.

Tensions were further exacerbated when each party acquired Cold War patrons. The Soviet Union and Cuba came to back the MPLA while the U.S. and apartheid South Africa moved to make UNITA their proxy. With battlelines drawn, Angola erupted into three decades of civil war.

HISTORIANS DISAGREE ON the sheer human cost of the conflict, although most estimates indicate some 500,000 lives were lost. An additional four million people—approximately one-third of Angola's total population—were internally displaced.

"Most of Angola's infrastructure and roads were either destroyed or provided no maintenance during the war," explained Vladimir Russo, President of Fundacao Kissama, an Angolan conservation group, in an interview with *The Politic*.

"At the same time," Russo continued, "the natural parks and wildlife areas had no protection."

These factors, coupled together, resulted in what Funston called an "intense utilization" of Angola's fauna; game reserves were attacked from all sides. The MPLA and UNITA subsidized their military operations



PHOTO BY **KOSTADIN LUBCHANSKY**



PHOTO BY **BRIAN JOHN HUNTLEY**

through the ivory trade, gunning down elephants from helicopters and selling their tusks on the black market. Meanwhile, civilians had no choice but to rely on harvesting bushmeat—much less a practice of bloodlust than an outcome of people's will to survive.

The aerial killing campaigns eventually came to an end as the rebel groups settled on a peace agreement in April 2002. But bushmeat—or *carne de zaza* in Portuguese—is still commonplace, if not traditional, after so many years. This is particularly true in the underdeveloped, southeastern portions of the country that were less impacted by the growth of Luanda's petroleum sector throughout the 1990s.

"Everyday you see people cooking bushmeat and drying it on racks…there's no sense in people's minds that this is a problem," Funston said while recounting his most recent visit to Angola.

Huntley communicated a similar experience from an expedition in 2014, noting how a rural commercial hub was rich with "a wide range of forest animals…bushbuck, blue duiker, monkeys, and pangolin staked out fresh, wet and bloody."

Decades of aggressive poaching have precipitated what ecologists call a bottom-up trophic cascade: a process by which the removal of primary consumers causes a ripple effect across an ecosystem. In Angola's case, the relative absence of common ungulates like wildebeest and red buffalo has severely reduced the number of top predators—particularly lions.

"At some point in the last 200 years, there must have been around 1,000 to 1,500 lions in the ecosystem," Funston stated with regard to the 32,000 square mile Cuando Cubango province in southeast Angola.

"Right now, there are between 10 and 30 across the entire region."

GIVEN THESE REALITIES, Huntley, Funston, and Russo believe conservation groups face a two-pronged challenge. The need to restore and fortify Angola's nature preserves goes without saying. The more difficult task is convincing local populations to reject the resources that have traditionally brought them food security and adopt more sustainable development goals. In effect, it would entail getting communities to stop hunting the animals they have relied on for generations.

"Protecting wildlife is really the solution for long term socio-economic empowerment," Funston stated in reference to booming eco-tourism sectors in Botswana, Kenya, and Tanzania. The short-term value of bushmeat is undeniable; a single roan antelope can sell for 250 dollars in Angola's larger markets. But Funston argues that moving away from a subsistence economic model is critical for the development of the country's remote regions.

In 2014, the African Development Bank (AfDB) estimated safari-related industries reaped in more than 43.6 billion dollars across the continent. In short, conservation has tremendous commercial value—particularly for a country like Angola that needs to

reduce its economy's reliance on volatile diamond and petroleum revenues.

There is, however, a troubling undercurrent in the calls for economic transition. Practically speaking, it would require Angolans to abandon long-held cultural practices in favor of a service-based economy that would primarily cater to wealthy tourists. Some find this notion, assessed alongside the country's history with the West, more than slightly disconcerting.

Still, the financial prospects have been more than enough to win over the Angolan government.The country's recent pivot towards conservation has been aggressive. Hundreds of former rebel soldiers have been re-trained as wildlife rangers over the last ten years, and authorities in Luanda have worked to shut down popular bushmeat markets and the poaching operations that supply them.

"The biggest challenge is still management," according to Russo. He notes that most of the parks' infrastructures—including roads and bridges—need to be rebuilt. Dozens of agricultural settlements must be removed from protected areas, and demining missions across Angola's 31,000 acres of confirmed minefields have proceeded slower than expected.

Even after sixteen years of peace, in Huntley's eyes, the country is just beginning to recover. But the steps toward conservation—and economic security—are promising. Species that have endured up to this point can flourish with proper protection, and those caught as casualties of war can be reintroduced with time.

In the conclusion of his book, Huntley calls on a popular Angolan motto: *esperança é a última coisa a morrer*—hope is the last thing to die.



PHOTO BY **BRIAN JOHN HUNTLEY**

DEVOTIONAL ACTIVISM

Abdul-Rehman Malik conducts experiments in social justice.

BY **TRAVIS DESHONG**

MIC IN HAND, 42-year-old Abdul-Rehman Malik, a Yale World Fellow, ushered the few stragglers toward tables with vacant seats. It was Saturday, February 17, the second day of the Ivy Muslims Conference. More than 100 students, split into ten groups, sat in a dining hall at the Saint Thomas More Catholic Chapel & Center. Malik, a large man with gentle eyes, a full graying beard, and his trademark tan fedora, prepared to introduce the Coffeehouse Exchange activity to the students. An educator at heart, he could not resist a teaching moment.

"It was in Istanbul where the coffeehouse became an art form," he explained. "It became a place for artists, writers, intellectuals, chess players, people from different strata to come together. The coffeehouse was and is a place for raw, unmediated dialogue."

Conference organizers copied and distributed five different papers between the ten groups. On each paper was a paragraph of thoughts and questions about an intersection of Islam and social justice. The students at every table discussed their topics for half an hour. Then, after two students from each group were appointed ambassadors, the ambassadors rotated clockwise to fill the empty spots at a new table. The travellers carried ideas from the home table with them and infused them into new conversations, gaining new insights as they proceeded around the room. Malik zipped from group to group, picking up fragments of engaged discussion. He had designed the activity himself, drawing on years of experience writing, teaching, and organizing.

"I was a high school teacher for five years, then I quit," he said. "I drove

> "There was always a connection between the devotional life and the activist life."

my colleagues up the wall because I made my classrooms laboratories for different sorts of learning."

He describes his goal as the "cross-fertilization" of ideas. During the conference, he encouraged everyone to be bold as they informed their worldviews. The students would see the combined power of faith and education that has defined most of Malik's life.

"ONE THING THAT'S become clear to me, since coming to Yale, is how lost even the most intelligent people feel," Malik said.

Other people across the country and around the world feel similarly disoriented. With Donald Trump's presidential victory and the rise of right-wing populist movements in Europe, demagoguery contends with rational discourse, alternative facts with academia, and atavistic national impulses with multicultural tolerance. These differences have uncovered deep divisions in our societies, and the question Malik asks is if and how those gaps can be bridged.

For Malik, a devout Muslim in an Islamophobic part of the world, the exchange of stories and experiences highlights what unites us. His appreciation for such exchange is built on a life of intellectual diversity, positive religion, and civic action.

Born in Toronto in 1975, Malik described his parents as "burn the boat immigrants." They embraced their Canadian status, emphasizing hard work and assimilation to their children. Yet Malik could feel the weight of the past pressed against his back.

Malik's grandparents and great-grandparents lived in the then-British Punjab Province, which comprises areas of modern-day eastern Pakistan and northern India. His father's family came from Amritsar, while his mother's originated from Jalandhar.

After the 1947 Partition split the Punjab between India and Pakistan, members on both sides of Malik's family became migrants. His maternal grandmother, 21 years old at the time, was out in the field plowing and picking eggs from the hens when somebody from the neighboring village appeared. They told her their village had just been razed and that she had to evacuate immediately. Malik's paternal grandmother fled Amritsar before a wave of violence engulfed the city.

Toronto is Malik's home, but, growing up, his feet were planted in different worlds. His father was an activist in Pakistani politics. His mother filled the house with books in Urdu, Punjabi, and English that covered the Islamic Revolution, political parties, and cultural manifestos. To the Maliks, the politics of the Middle East and South Asia mattered as much as those of Canada. Journalists, artists, and politicians, including the future president of Afghanistan, Burhanuddin Rabbani, debated politics in their living room. At his mosque, Malik learned about Mansa Musa and the Muslim empires of Timbuktu. Prayer, reading the Qur'an, and the devotional life were all indispensable in his confessional household.

"There was always a connection between the devotional life and the activist life," Malik said. "My devotion meant certain ethics. That's what I saw in my parents and in my community."

When he arrived as an undergraduate student at the University of Toronto, Malik's activist identity began to take shape. He became involved with student politics and rose to be the president of the Muslim Students Association. The group created the *Muslim Voice*, the first monthly Muslim newspaper on any Canadian university campus. Malik leapt at the opportunity to write, and his articles captured the attention of left-wing publications in the city.

"I'm deeply invested in th

In the spring of 1995, President George H. W. Bush was scheduled to receive an honorary degree from the University of Toronto. Students, staff, and faculty mobilized immediately, pressuring the university to move the ceremony from the convocation hall to a smaller venue. Demonstrating against Bush because of his policies in the Gulf War, the protesters surrounded the building and made enough noise to warrant a police presence.

"Wow, it sounds like happy hour at the Baghdad Holiday Inn," the president said, according to Malik, who scoffed at the remark. Most striking to him, however, was the walk-out that a group of impassioned professors staged during the ceremony. The students applauded and welcomed them onto their own makeshift stage just outside.

"We were building alliances in those days," Malik said. "And within Muslim communities that kind of alliance-building work had never happened before. We were seeing ourselves as a community tied to other social justice interests."

OMER BAJWA, the Director of Muslim Life in Yale's Chaplain Office, first met Malik in March 2001. The University of Toronto was hosting a weeklong conference on classical Islamic education, and Malik was one of the primary organizers. The organization and structure of the conference impressed Bajwa, and his respect for Malik's prowess as an educator has only grown over the last two decades.

"He is deeply grounded in traditional Islamic values, spiritual leadership and academic scholarship," Bajwa said. "And he's able to articulate these things in a very contemporary voice. He can be in conversation with multiple perspectives."

This semester, Bajwa and Malik are co-teaching a discussion seminar at Yale called "A Change is Going to Come: Exploring Islamic Theologies of Political and Social Transformation." The class takes inspiration from the Arabic world *halaqa*, meaning circle or ring. In the Islamic faith, a *halaqa* is a religious gathering for the study of Islam and the Qur'an. Malik and Bajwa apply Islamic theology and philosophy to critical debates about difficult political topics such as war, occupation, corruption, and political instability, including the state of the Muslim world post-Arab Spring.

"Abdul-Rehman Malik knows how to navigate the complexities and tensions of these issues," wrote one of Malik's students, Zeshan Gondal '19, in an email interview with *The Politic*. "He brings the compassion and wisdom that comes with working actively in local communities across the UK and around the world."

Malik spent part of his summers in the U.K. from 1995 to 2003, when he moved there full-time. London is his "first love," he said. He studied for a Masters degree at the London School of Economics and immersed himself in journalism, writing weekly at *Q-News,* a British monthly magazine that published cultural, political, and religious Muslim stories. In 2010, he became a regular contributor to BBC Radio, discussing spirituality on the air for Radio 2's breakfast show and in documentaries for Radio 4 and the World Service. London's diversity dazzled him. He described a November 2003 demonstration against the Iraq War as a "victory," where traditionally-clad Muslim women and men marched alongside LGBTQ+ activists.

Building coalitions is not always easy. While working on the Stop the War movement in Toronto around the same time, Malik learned about the complexities involved in bringing diverse people together and steering them toward consensus and action.

"Our LGBTQ+ brothers and sisters came to the table and said they didn't know if they could work

his thing called America."

with the Muslim community," Malik said. "We can't change prejudices overnight. But we can begin with respect and what we find common ground on."

The London bombings on July 7, 2015 pushed Malik to translate his blend of faith and education into activism. He helped found the Radical Middle Way non-profit shortly afterward. The organization works with grassroots partners in the U.K. and around the world to create platforms for debate and spiritual reflection. "Middle Way" refers to a moderate understanding of Islam, free of the extremism that often defines it in the public imagination.

"The problem of violent extremism is not too much religion, but not enough good religion," he said. "Religion has an ethical dimension that should ground and guide us as citizens."

These are the lessons that guide Malik in his work at Yale, both as a World Fellow and a Postgraduate Associate at the MacMillan Center's Council on Middle Eastern Studies. Since he arrived in New Haven in August, Malik has organized 17 events. He chaired "The Good, The Bad and The Ugly: The Politics of Storytelling" in October, a panel to discuss how storytelling can promote resilience in unintended ways. In November, he brought award-winning Canadian journalist Nazim Baksh to reveal how the West covers Islamist terrorism in a talk called "Jihad in the Newsroom".

"AR [Abdul-Rehman] makes 'ordinary' folk feel that they are citizens," Lucy Sternbach, '19, who worked on the "Politics of Storytelling" panel, wrote in an email to *The Politic*. "He makes them feel that they have to pay some dues, that they have power in making everyday decisions."

In December, Malik joined English professor David Kastan and English Touring Theatre theater director Richard Twyman to host "Moor, Monster, ...Muslim: Rethinking Shakespeare's *Othello*." The event explored how the famous tragedy, and art in general, forces us to think about identity and community.

"What Abdul-Rehman is, I suppose, is a joiner, a mender, a healer," Kastan said in an email interview with *The Politic*. "The example of his own generous and capacious mind shows a way out of the constraining boxes of our thinking."

SINCE TRUMP'S ELECTION, Malik has continued to think critically about "this thing called America"—an "empire," he said, that is trying to come to terms with itself and its legacy.

According to Malik, our democratic political system is broken, and the gender divide remains vast. There are deep, racial fault lines. In his view, we have yet to address our nation's original sin: the genocide committed against the indigenous population.

"And as a scholar, as a journalist, where do you want to be? You want be in a place where all these discussions are happening," he said.

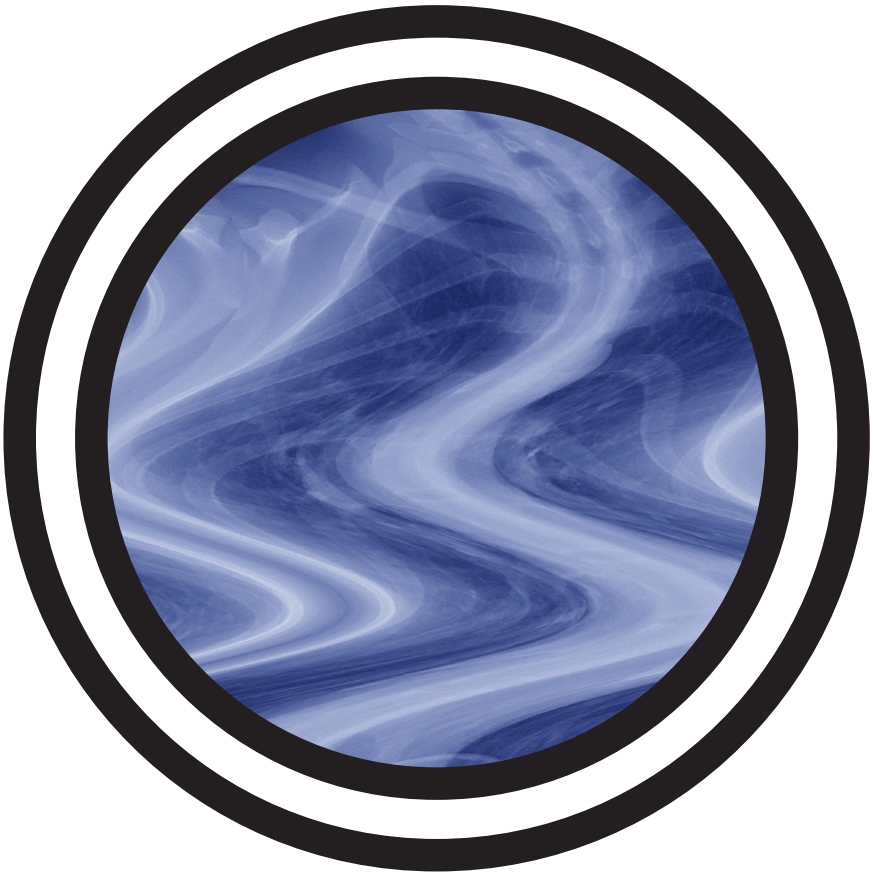
Over 9,000 miles away from New Haven, in Jakarta, Bandung, and other cities, another coalition-building project is happening in typical Malik fashion. Kafe Cerita, The Cafe of Stories, pairs Muslims and non-Muslims to share their stories about leadership, resilience, and progress and pushes the participants to find common ground. Americans that Malik has spoken with about this project identify a need in our culture for a similar sort of reconciliation and commitment to change—for a new American story. Malik isn't sure that America is ready to find that new story, but he has more than enough faith.

"I am in many ways an intellectual child of what America has given," Malik said. "I'm a product of Malcolm X, of Walt Whitman and Thoreau and Emerson. Of John Coltrane and Bob Dylan. I'm deeply invested in this thing called America."

BLIND SPOTS

transgender cancer patients fight their disease and our medical system

BY **SARAH DONILON**



ON AN APRIL MORNING IN 2016,

Casey Sexton, a burly and tattooed 54-year-old with a brown goatee and blue eyes, was on his way to work, at a Jared Galleria of Jewelry branch in Madison, Wisconsin, when his doctor called with the biopsy results: stage IIIA breast cancer. "Well that sucks," Sexton remembers replying. After the call with his doctor, and before he knew he would need three surgeries and eight rounds of chemotherapy, Sexton went to work for the day. "That's kind of how I roll," he told me over the phone with a chuckle.

Long before then, Sexton had accepted that, at some point, he would probably get lung cancer from smoking, or liver cancer from drinking. Breast cancer, though, was unthinkable, since Sexton didn't have breasts anymore.

Five years earlier, in 2011, Sexton had undergone top surgery. He had been saving up for the procedure since 1999, when he started taking testosterone. (Sexton identifies as a transgender man.) It was not until 2010, when he won the jackpot at Madison's Dejope Casino, that he had the 6,500 dollars he needed. The top surgery eliminated the breasts with which he was born, and with them—he assumed at the time—any risk of breast cancer. And so, four years later, when Sexton felt a lump in his chest, he suspected it was scar tissue from the surgery. For six months, he avoided the doctor's office until the lump grew too big and too painful to ignore.

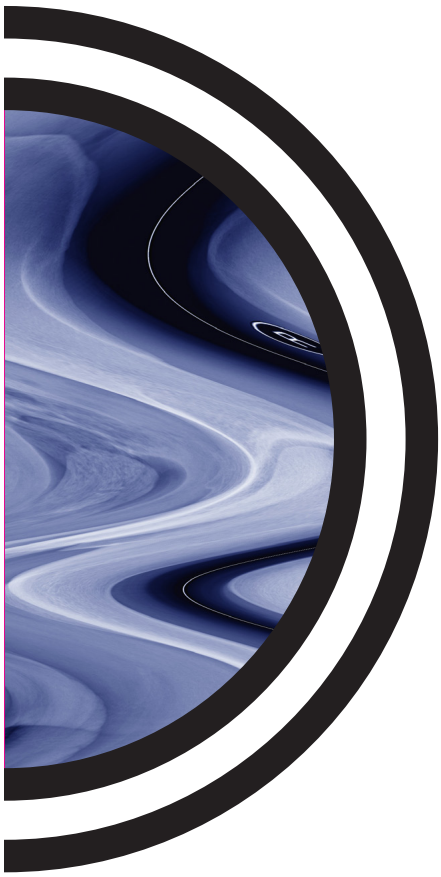
Now, Sexton wonders what might have been different had he visited a doctor earlier. By the time he did, the cancer had spread to more than 20 of his lymph nodes. "If I'd been diligent about it and got it checked out, it wouldn't have been as severe as it was," he said. "That was a dumb-ass move." But Sexton's doctors had never told him to get his chest checked out. Even they hadn't known he should.

TRANSGENDER AMERICANS SUFFER FROM

a shortage of specified care and research in a medical system not designed to care for them. These patients carry a double burden: their medical diagnosis and obstacles related to their gender identity. In the most extreme cases, doctors refuse outright to treat transgender people. More common, however, are subtler complications. In every stage of accessing quality healthcare—from obtaining insurance to finding a competent doctor, from outing themselves in waiting rooms to having invasive exams—transgender patients face particular challenges.

Cancer is one of the highest risk diagnoses for transgender people with poor medical care. And "gendered" cancers—those associated with one biological sex, like breast and cervical cancer—especially increase the likelihood of discrimination or complication. Cases like Casey Sexton's pose a new question for the medical community: What happens when transgender people are diagnosed with diseases—especially cancers—associated with the biological sex they've left behind?

Some transgender patients, like Sexton, see doctors who want to treat them but don't have the proper training to do it; others see doctors who have studied all available information about transgender health, but are still limited by insufficient medical research. "There are blind spots upon blind spots," said Juno Obedin-Maliver, a resident physician



in Obstetrics and Gynecology at the University of California, San Francisco.

For Sexton, the biggest obstacle was a lack of information about his own health. Top surgery, which he underwent, is the most common of gender-affirming surgeries. In the procedure, doctors remove most—but not all—of the patient's breast tissue, leaving enough to construct a cosmetically-masculine chest. By contrast, in a mastectomy—the goal of which is to prevent or treat breast cancer—doctors remove as much breast tissue as possible. With less breast tissue, the risk of breast cancer for people who transition from female to male decreases significantly, but it doesn't disappear. "People should know it's still possible," Sexton said.

Sexton insists his doctors were supportive—"I think they felt bad for me"—but they were unable to properly advise him. They could, and should, have told him that breast cancer was still a possibility. How he should look out for it, though, is a question to which medical experts have different answers.

"Breast cancer screening guidelines are completely inadequate for transgender individuals right now," said Mandi Pratt-Chapman, a health equity researcher at George Washington University hospital in Washington, D.C. Only one organization has published guidelines on breast cancer screening in transgender men: The World Professional Association for Transgender Health (WPATH) recommends transgender men be screened for breast cancer every two years. But a factsheet from the Center of Excellence for Transgender Health at the University of California San Francisco reads: "No reliable evidence exists to guide the screening of transgender men who have undergone mastectomy."

Other considerations are psychological. As a procedure designed predominantly for women, mammography can be uncomfortable for people who have transitioned from female to male. "That's a really big thing," said AC Demidont, an infectious disease specialist who leads Anchor Health Initiative, an organization that serves New Haven's LGBTQ community.

Transgender people might also fear the discrimination that seeking a mammogram could involve. "If they don't 'pass'—which I hate that word, by the way, 'pass,' because I certainly don't pass," said Demidont, who identifies as a transgender woman. "But if it's evident to the person doing the exam that this person is trans, there could be a lot of perceived and real bias from a technician performing the exam." Passing refers to a transgender person appearing to be, or "passing" as, a cisgender person, meaning someone who identifies with his or her biological sex.

To make matters more complicated, there is not enough research to confirm that mammography is the most effective method of screening for transgender men who have had top surgery. Transgender men's chests post-surgery are different from cisgender women's. A mammogram involves an x-ray machine that compresses the breast from above and below; without much breast tissue, the procedure can be painful, besides possibly being ineffective. (When Sexton had a mammogram after his diagnosis, "it hurt like crazy.")

Lack of research on cancer in transgender populations is representative of a broader absence of data on gender minority health. The U.S. Census Bureau asks no questions related to gender identity, nor to sexual orientation. Those questions are also often not asked in less formal settings, like doctor's offices and research studies. An estimated 1.4 million transgender people live in the U.S., based on a 2016 compilation, but that number is widely believed to be underreported.

Recent efforts, both on the public and private levels, have sought to remedy this problem. As part of an initiative called "Do Ask, Do Tell," the National LGBT Health Education Center at the Fenway Institute in Boston recommended that all patients be asked their sexual orientation and gender identity on patient registration forms. Rather than two options—M and F—to describe their gender, patients at Fenway Health now have seven, including the option to state one's own additional gender category. The next question on the form asks for the sex listed on the patient's birth certificate: "Male," "Female," or "Decline to Answer."

Without data, doctors are sometimes left to assume transgender patients have the same risk factors, screening procedures, and treatment options as cisgender people. But both their physiology and external circumstances are different. Demidont noted, for example, that social determinants of health—homelessness, discrimination, mental health challenges, and in

Sexton's case, alcohol and tobacco use—all disproportionately affect transgender people.

As Obedin-Maliver said, "You can't treat what you don't know."

WHEN LIAM GRANGER WAS A 21-YEAR-OLD

working at a K&W chain restaurant in North Carolina, he didn't yet go by Liam. Back then, in 2008, he wasn't out—even to himself—as transgender, but he felt increasingly disconnected from his female body, so much so that it was not until he visited his doctor (for unexplained stomach pain) that he realized he had not menstruated for eight months.

The doctors examined Granger and diagnosed him with stage IV level B cervical cancer, which meant the disease had spread to other parts of his body: liver, one kidney, intestines, and bladder. With every pelvic exam that followed, Granger recalls, he went into "dysphoric downfalls for days at a time," the feeling of discordance between his gender identity as a transgender man and the biologically female disease for which he was being treated.

"I knew I had to have it done, so I had to push that down," he says now of his discomfort with the exams. He needed them urgently: Granger's doctor told him that if he hadn't immediately received treatment, he wouldn't have lived to see his 22nd birthday.

After eight months of treatment, Granger went into remission. But in early 2017, his cervical cancer returned. This time, Granger decided to come out to his doctor in the hopes that he might have recommendations for therapists or LGBT-friendly medical centers. Before his appointment, Granger googled "How to come out as trans to your medical provider." The doctor would be one of the first people to whom he came out. After Granger said what he had rehearsed, the doctor was "short" with him. And for the first time, he didn't shake Granger's hand on his way out the door.

Later, when Granger called to make a new appointment, a receptionist informed him that his doctor had dropped him as a patient. The doctor's reaction surprised Granger: "I thought he would be a little bit more medically professional about it," he said.

"You focus on the disease but you also want to be respected," Granger told me. "Even if you don't want to call me my name, at least please take care of me."

Since then, he has found a new and more accepting doctor, through a recommendation from a transgender friend online. Still, while continuing to undergo treatment and checkups, Granger receives confused reactions from

"Even if you don't want to call me my name, at least please take care of me."





people about his diagnosis. When Granger says he has cervical cancer, others sometimes ask, "Do you mean testicular cancer?"

"Gynecology" comes from the Greek gyne and logia; it means "the study of woman." At the gynecologist's office in North Carolina, Granger was not surprised to be surrounded by women. But they were surprised to see him.

During one visit to his OB/GYN's office, in August 2017, Granger sat alone with an older woman—white, petite, and in her 70s—across the small room. The woman looked at Granger and approached the front desk. "Why is he here having an appointment at the OB/GYN?" she asked the receptionist, who "kinda giggled it off." Granger didn't respond; he didn't want to cause any more of a scene. "I get looked at like I'm a freak of nature," he said.

WHEN CASEY SEXTON RECEIVED

his breast cancer diagnosis, his doctors advised that he consider halting his hormone therapy, because of its unknown cancer risks. For Sexton, those risks were worth it. He continued his testosterone therapy while receiving chemotherapy for breast cancer.

Like most areas of transgender health, the long-term effects of hormones on cancer risk are based on conjecture. According to one fact sheet from the UCSF transgender center, "it is unclear if testosterone therapy plays any role in HPV infections or cervical cancer" and "testosterone treatment does not seem to significantly increase the risk of breast cancer, but there's not enough research to be certain." Without sufficient funding, or a large sample size of transgender people on hormone therapy for an extended period of time, doctors assume potential risks of hormone use in cancer treatment.

The data that does exist on hormones is largely not sourced from studies of the transgender community. One established fact in more general scientific literature, for example, is that excess testosterone (which transgender men take if they undergo hormone replacement therapy) can convert to estrogen. In cisgender women—those who are born as, and identify as, female—estrogen has been shown to increase breast cancer risk. And so it is possible that the testosterone supplements transgender men take could convert to estrogen, which could potentially increase cancer risk. This makes screenings all the more important.

Liam Granger recalls his doctor telling him that "doing the hormone route was my choice, but there was not a guarantee I wouldn't be diagnosed with another cancer down the line." He wishes there were more research on the long-term effects of hormone therapy, but even without the data, his calculation was not difficult.

"If it's gonna be like an every-ten-year diagnosis type thing, and I have to go through chemo and radiation to be who I am, I'm going to keep taking them," he said. "I would rather—this is gonna sound really bad," he paused. "But I would rather die happy than miserable."

VAN BAILEY, NOW AN ADMINISTRATOR

at the University of Miami, very quickly realized his new doctor hadn't read his chart. The doctor, a primary care physician in Boston, assumed Bailey was a cisgender man. (In his official headshot online, Bailey wears

"What's 'LGBT?'" the doctor asked. "Oh, God," Bailey thought.

a polka-dotted bow tie and has a shaved head, a beard, and a wide smile with a gap between his two front teeth.) His medical records, unopened in a folder the doctor carried with her, noted Bailey is transgender. Before the appointment began, during a few moments of small talk, the doctor asked Bailey what his job was; he was the director of LGBT student life at Harvard, he told her. "What's 'LGBT?'" the doctor asked. "Oh, God," Bailey thought.

"The appointment went downhill from there," Bailey recalled. He knew the doctor was trying to help; she frantically studied his medical records and looked up some information, but their twenty minutes together was not nearly enough time to both educate her and assess him. After that experience and others like it, Bailey avoided visiting the doctor as much as possible. "I have to do so much labor to make sure I'm not treated shitty," he explained.

Bailey understands the physical repercussions of skipping doctor's appointments. "It's why I'm in the health state that I'm in now," he said matter-of-factly. (Bailey's hormone and liver levels are off, and his blood pressure is creeping higher.) "I just haven't been to the doctor, and when I have gone it's been really crappy."

For some doctors, like Bailey's, the problem is insufficient transgender health-related education, which has its roots in narrow medical school curricula. A 2011 study that Obedin-Maliver co-authored found that only 40 of 132 medical schools included any transgender health in their curricula. As a result, half of transgender patients reported having to educate their health care providers about their own health, in a 2010 study.

Education in treating transgender patients isn't limited to medical knowledge. Cultural competency training opportunities are also few and far between. In 2015, the Fenway Institute of Health issued a report with recommendations to improve cervical screening of transgender men. Bailey agreed to participate, "because I wanted information on what's going to be happening with getting paps and things like that," he told me. His doctor hadn't discussed with him whether he still needed the exams after transitioning from female to male. Unlike breast cancer, cervical cancer has unambiguous screening guidelines: Anyone with a cervix needs a pelvic exam. Most transgender men still have cervixes. Two thirds of transgender people do not have surgery to alter their gender at all. And if transgender men do, it will likely be top surgery; hysterectomies are less common.

Before transitioning, Bailey had already had dysphoria—the feeling of mismatch between gender identity and biological sex that Granger also felt during pelvic exams—while at the gynecologist, and was nervous to return.

The Fenway report recommends "describing cervical cancer screening as a non-gendered cancer screening procedure," to make these necessary exams more comfortable for transgender people. For Bailey, thoughtful communication from his doctor was helpful. At the gynecologist's office, Bailey's new doctor discussed with him the need for pelvic exams, presented them as necessary for his health, and explained how he would be able to perform the procedure so that it was as comfortable as possible. "I loved the language that he used," Bailey said.

Cultural competence measures are not important only for the sake of sensitivity; they could be lifesaving. As Bailey's case testifies, the manner in which different doctors treat patients affects whether patients continue to seek out medical care.

In general, transgender men are much less likely to have pelvic exams than cisgender women are. A study published in 2017 found that half of transgender men surveyed

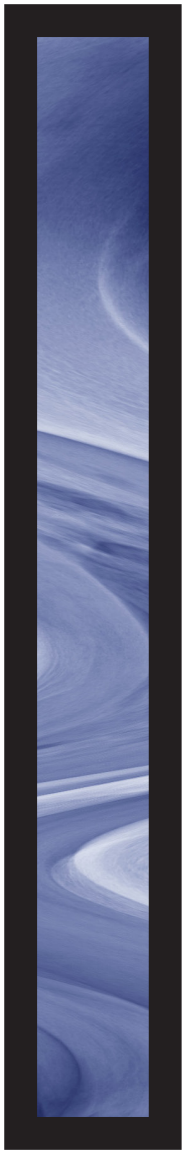
had not had a pelvic exam in the past three years. What's more, transgender men are ten times more likely than cisgender women to have medically sub-standard, cursory pelvic exams, according to a 2014 study. As a result, said Pratt-Chapman of George Washington hospital, "People are very likely unnecessarily dying of cervical cancer when it could be avoided."

AFTER HE STARTED TREATMENT

for breast cancer, Casey Sexton received a call from his insurance company. The chemotherapy would not be covered, because of administrative confusion: He was listed as male with his employer, but his medical records showed he had "female breast cancer." To receive coverage, Sexton would have to change his gender back to female at work."Yeah, it really sucked," he said of the switch. He has high praise for his employer, Jared's Jewelry, and fears what would happen if he had to switch jobs and explain his situation to a less understanding boss.

Liam Granger has taken a new job to help afford his treatment, while undergoing chemotherapy. Amid battles with his insurance company that included mailing his birth certificate and several letters from doctors explaining he was transgender, he briefly considered applying for the Affordable Care Act. The ACA not only covers most aspects of gender transition, including hormones and surgery, but also protects against gender discrimination, including against transgender patients. Just 17 states have laws that explicitly protect against insurance or Medicaid transgender discrimination.

In the end, Granger decided against applying for ACA coverage. Most of all, he was dubious that any federal policy under the Trump Administration could protect him. "With Trump's stance on pulling trans people from the army, I was like, 'This isn't going to be any better,'" he said. Last summer, Granger read tweets from the president, in which he pledged to ban transgender people from the military.



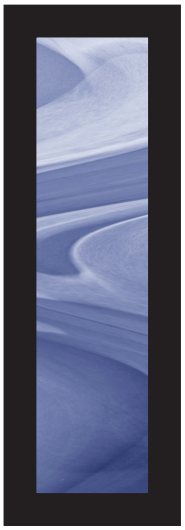
Trump cited "tremendous medical costs" as the reason to prohibit transgender troops. But a study conducted in 2015 found that the cost of gender transition care would amount to an estimated 22 cents per military member per month, "little more than a rounding error in the military's $47.8 billion annual health care budget," according to the study's author. Sexton began to fume when I asked him about the president's statements. "These people are willing to die and you won't let them serve because of who they are—what?"

In December 2017, the Trump Administration's Department of Justice announced it would not appeal federal court rulings that challenged the ban. On January 1, 2018, openly transgender troops were permitted to enlist.

Several weeks later, the Trump Administration announced, through its Health and Human Services civil rights office, that it would protect health workers who refuse to treat transgender patients. They will have the power to object thanks to a new "Conscience and Religious Freedom" provision.

"This is when I don't sound intelligent," Sexton said while we discussed Trump. "I get so frustrated that I start to stutter. And I can't believe that this is happening."

CASEY SEXTON WAS SHOCKED

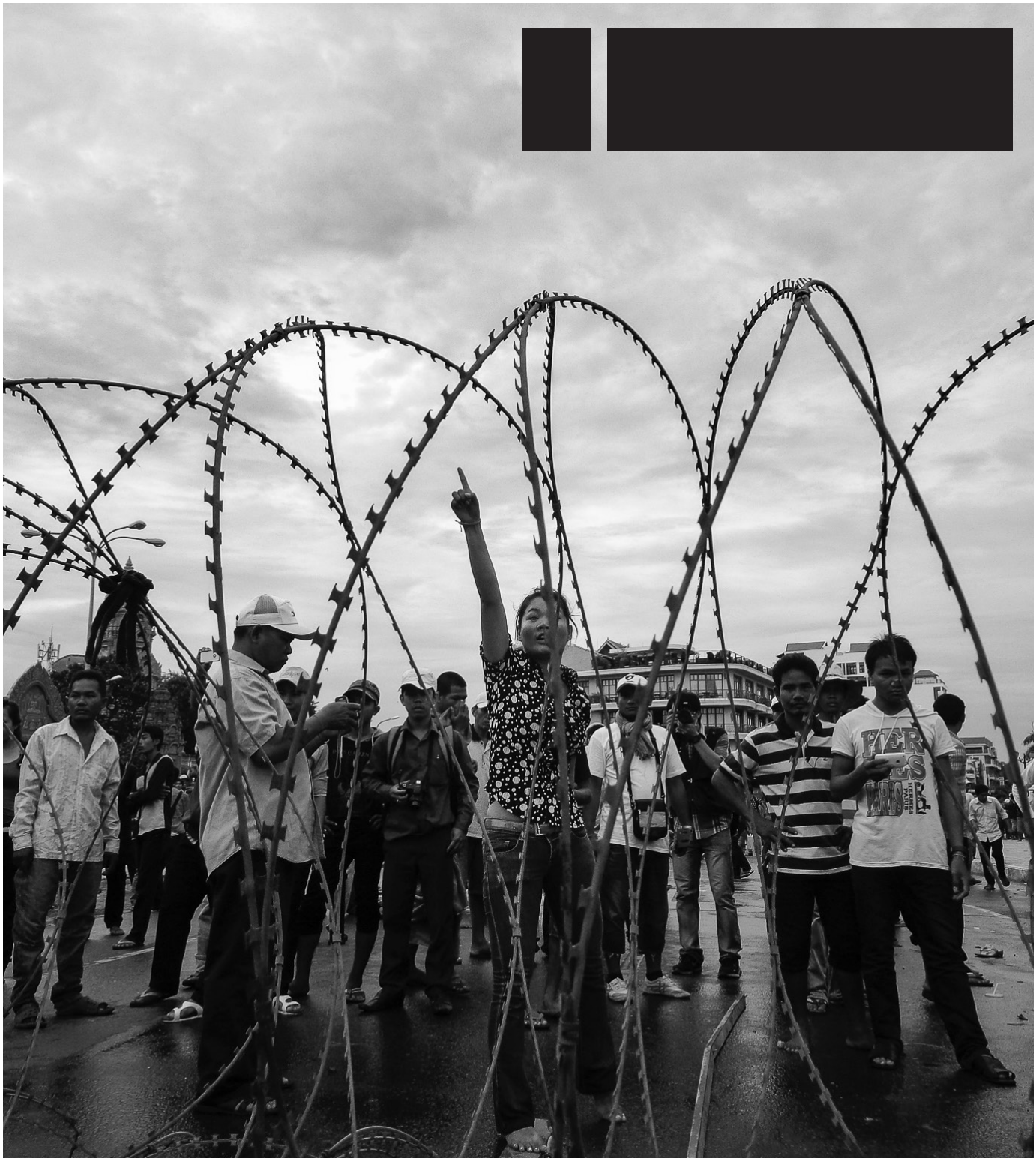


that I wanted to talk to him about his gender transition. When I first contacted him over Facebook, he responded with an emoji-filled (mostly the winking smiley face with a tongue sticking out) message: "I have to say 'wow. Really' I have never known anyone that has given a shit about that."

Sexton feels lucky to have supportive doctors and a welcoming family. But none of them completely understands his situation, and he's had trouble finding anyone else who does. Sexton knows very few transgender people. His doctors had heard of one transgender person in Colorado with the same diagnosis, but Sexton was uninterested in baring his soul to a stranger by phone.

Sexton told me he has approached his cancer diagnosis with the same attitude he had when friends rejected him after his gender transition nearly twenty years ago.

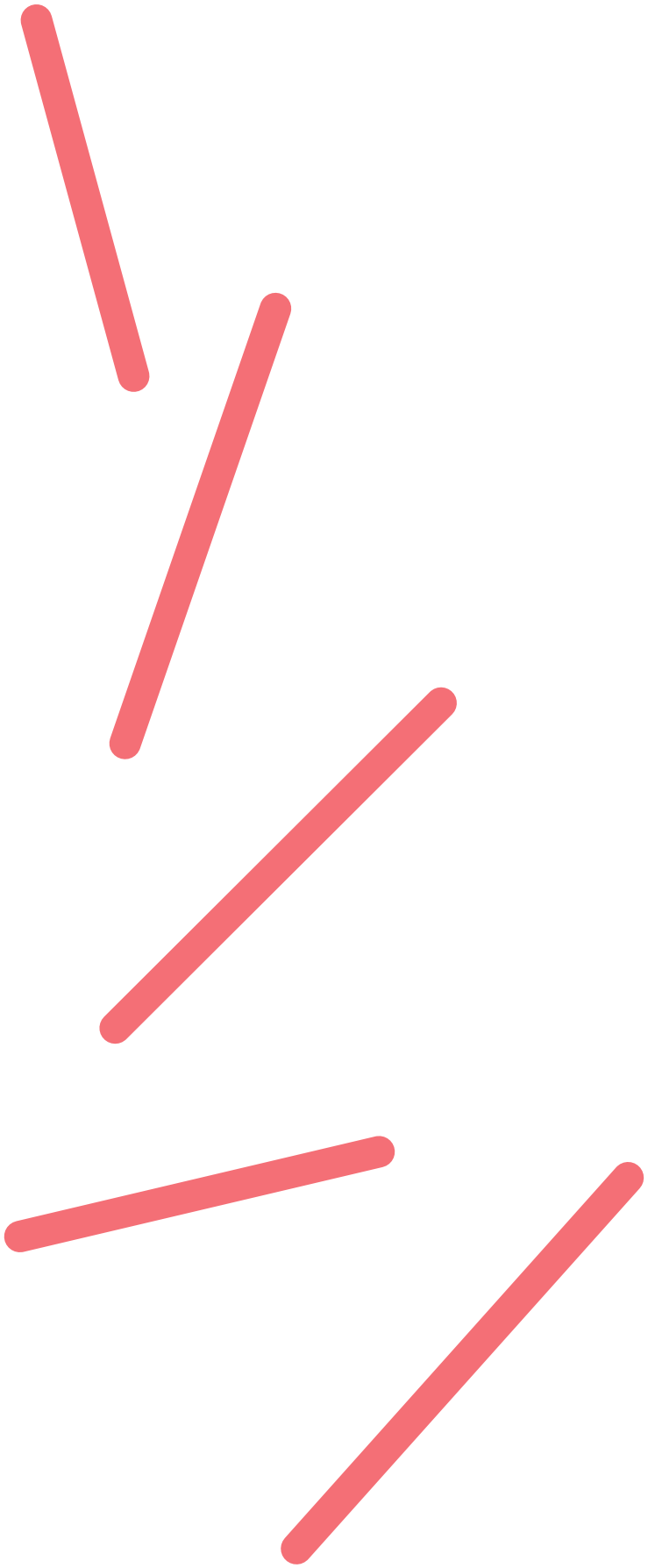
In a situation like his, he said, "You're kind of on your own."



IMAGES COURTESY OF **NATHAN THOMPSON**

Scare Tactics and Silencing: Hun Sen's Brutal Crackdown on Opposition in Cambodia

BY **ELLA FANGER**



IN JANUARY 2002, SEVEN-YEAR-OLD Sokreth Un was too young to understand why his father, Sokhom, had been run off the road by a large truck in the Odong district of Cambodia. Sokhom Un had been travelling from district to district with fellow members of the opposition Sam Rainsy Party, campaigning ahead of upcoming local elections.

It would not be the last time Sokhom was targeted for his opposition to the regime of Cambodian Prime Minister Hun Sen. Sokhom was a journalist who owned a paper, *Proyuth*, "To Fight Against" in English. One day in August 2002, Sokhom and a friend dropped off the paper at the printer around midnight, according to Sokhom's personal statement from his 2005 U.S. asylum application, which Sokreth shared with *The Politic* in an email. That day, two soldiers had come to the paper's office and demanded to speak with Sokhom, but he was out reporting.

On his way back from the printer, Sokhom noticed two cars following closely behind him. He took two or three turns to confirm the cars were trailing him—they were. His friend suggested switching cars to confuse the pursuers. The last thing Sokhom remembers is opening his friend's car door and being struck by a vehicle.

When Sokhom awoke in the hospital, his friend told him the car that struck him was a big Mercedes driven by a man in a military uniform.

Sokhom barely survived the attack: Most of the skin on his back and arm was scraped off. He filed a complaint with the government, but the major general who ran him over claimed it was an accident. Four soldiers visited Sokhom in the hospital and expressed surprise that he was still alive.

After the "accident," Sokhom's family decided the brutal political violence of the Hun Sen regime made staying in Cambodia too dangerous. They moved to the U.S. in 2006, when Sokreth was eleven. Now, over a decade later, Sokreth is a student at the University of Massachusetts Lowell, which has a sizable Cambodian population. Sokreth serves as president of the university's Cambodian American Student Association.

In Cambodia, Hun Sen remains in power, and his regime continues to brutally crack down on individuals and political organizations who oppose it. Hun Sen is particularly concerned with his political survival ahead of the 2018 national elections. On October 6, 2017, the regime, now approaching its third decade in power, forcibly disbanded the Cambodia National Rescue Party (CNRP)—the country's main opposition party,

which grew out of a merger between the Sam Rainsy Party and another anti-government group.

As Sokreth's father experienced firsthand, news media is also considered a significant threat to the government. Cambodian journalists continue to fear repercussions from the government for publishing on sensitive issues like politics, logging, and corruption.

Hun Sen's efforts to consolidate power have also specifically targeted institutions and publications that represent U.S. influence in the country. The regime forced the closure of independent English-language media outlets like *The Cambodia Daily* and U.S.-funded civil society groups like the National Democratic Institute. In August and September, radio broadcasters relaying American-funded programs were ejected from the country or forced to withdraw, stifled by excessive restrictions placed on them by the government.

"The *Daily* was one of a couple newspapers in town that did investigations that went out and found stories that were often pretty unflattering for the government," Ben Paviour, a former reporter for the *Daily*, told *The Politic* in an interview. "They were stories that much [local language] Khmer media couldn't write or couldn't do politically because... the government would shut them down if they tried."

Though the regime occasionally threatened the *Daily* with retaliation for publishing critical pieces, the recent crackdown came with an unprecedented move to shut down the paper outright. Tej Parikh, a global policy analyst and journalist, told *The Politic* in an email that when he was a reporter for the *Daily* two years ago, "There were threats, stories of aggressive encounters with officials—but nothing quite compared to the recent crackdown."

According to Paviour, Hun Sen's latest actions have had a chilling effect on civil society organizations, NGOs, and the press.

"They're sensitive to the fact that they could be shut down," Paviour said. "Anyone the government decides is part of this color revolution could be next in the net."

Local journalists in particular fear for their physical safety. One reporter in Cambodia told the International Federation of Journalists, "Reporters talk about it being more dangerous now and there's lots of talk of our phones being tapped. Foreigners still have an easier time working here, they might be told to leave, but for locals it's much more difficult, especially for those with families."

Some local journalists have even been imprisoned or denied their press cards and thus stripped of their ability to provide for their families. The IFJ report reveals that Uon Chhin and Yeang Sothearin, two former local reporters for the U.S.-funded Radio Free Asia, were arrested on November 14, 2017 on charges of "providing information that is destructive to national defence to a foreign state." The incident highlights how Hun Sen has used ties to the U.S. to justify a crackdown on local journalists.

Meanwhile, the political opposition to the ruling Cambodian People's Party (CPP) has fractured. Opposition leader Sam Rainsy fled to France after a court found him guilty of defaming Hun Sen. Cambodian officials arrested Kem Sokha, the president of the CNRP, on treason charges the night before the *Daily*'s last day of reporting. Paviour, who helped cover the arrest for the *Daily*, said, "That was one of the biggest things to happen in the last year and things didn't really slow down after that."

What spurred this recent bout of repression by the Cambodian government? How are these attacks related to the tactics Sokreth's father faced over a decade earlier? Understanding the crackdown requires an appreciation for the complex relations between the U.S., the Cambodian people, and Hun Sen that have defined much of Cambodia's history since the late 1970s.

With support from Vietnam, Hun Sen's party overthrew Cambodia's infamous Khmer Rouge regime in 1979. But, seeking to combat Soviet influence in Southeast Asia, the U.S., China, and most of the West supported the Khmer Rouge—which had murdered two million people during its four-year rule—and other groups opposing the USSR-backed Hun Sen government in Phnom Penh. The U.S. provided diplomatic support to this resistance coalition through 1990.

Sebastian Strangio, a journalist and the author of *Hun Sen's Cambodia*, told *The Politic* that this contentious relationship has left a "legacy of bitterness" between the Hun Sen regime and the United States.

In 1991, Hun Sen, the Khmer Rouge, and other rebel factions signed a peace treaty brokered by the United States, the Soviet Union, and China. U.S. policy officials began to lecture a government they had tried to disband for over a decade on the importance of democracy.

To Hun Sen, who remembers U.S. political intervention in support of the Khmer Rouge as well

"Anyone the government decides is part of this color revolution could be next in the net."



as the extensive bombing of Cambodia by the U.S. during the Vietnam War, criticism of human rights abuses by American officials rings hollow at best and hypocritical at worst. In an October 2017 speech to 20,000 factory workers in Phnom Penh, Hun Sen said, "Now, we just use the law to protect... the security and peace of our country, but they said that we violate human rights. But [the U.S.] shot, killed, and dropped bombs on our people."

Indeed, Kosol Sek, the managing director of IKARE, a Minnesota-based non-profit that seeks to promote Khmer interests and preserve Khmer history, told *The Politic* that U.S. policy gives "the Cambodian people sort of a huffing and puffing-type feeling."

In 1992, the UN launched a peacekeeping mission in Cambodia that sought to establish democratic institutions in the country. Strangio said that since the '90s, Cambodia

has been a "hybrid form of semi-democracy, in which freedoms were permitted and tolerated in certain places at certain times."

In Phnom Penh, human rights activists contributed to a vibrant civil society, Two English-language newspapers and U.S.-funded radio broadcasts were allowed to voice criticism of the regime without much retribution. Meanwhile, local Khmer papers like the one owned by Sokreth's father were harshly stifled.

The colorful newsstands lining the streets of the capital belied a deeply repressive reality for the majority of Cambodia's citizens.

"The reason the government permitted these spaces to exist was precisely because they were quarantined from the heartland of Cambodia and the vast majority of the people," Strangio explained.

The Cambodia Daily, for instance, had a circulation of just 5,000 in a country of nearly 16 million prior to its shutdown. According to Strangio, the reality of Cambodia's free press was "tightly circumscribed by a wide range of formal and informal mechanisms."

As Josh Kurlantzick, a fellow at the Council on Foreign Relations, told *The Politic* when discussing the present crackdown, "Hun Sen has been using similar tactics in the past, but they have ebbed and flowed."

Strangio pointed out that Hun Sen has justified his most recent actions as "part of a wider pushback against foreign-funded NGOs and the presence of foreign money and influence in Cambodian politics." From the Cambodian government's perspective, Voice of America and Radio Free Asia—two American-backed programs shuttered by the regime—are not independent media outlets at all but tools to expand U.S. influence in the country. And when speaking about the U.S.-funded National Democratic Institute, Paviour acknowledged, "If China were in the U.S. funding some sort of organization providing training to the Democratic or Republican Party, that would be a huge deal."

Even if seen as a continuation of Hun Sen's cycles of repression and relaxation, the closure of newspapers and NGOs and the disbandment of the opposition party constitute a much more severe crackdown than has been seen in the past. So what has caused such a harsh response?

In the last parliamentary elections in 2013, the CNRP scored an unprecedented number of seats.

"Years in power, years of wealth, have created distances between [Hun Sen] and... the struggles of ordinary people," Strangio told *The Politic*. "He didn't realize the depths of the anger."

Though the CNRP did not enter government in 2013, it won almost 45 percent of the seats in parliament. (There is speculation that the party won even more seats than officially reported.)

Those results came despite the fact that, as Kurlantzick told *The Politic*, "the ruling party would use whatever levers it had to make the election not free, like not giving the opposition almost any time on TV, handing out money to CPP local party organizations, some degree of fraud, and repressing the vote in some places."

In the past, Strangio explained, the CPP "has been able to accomodate minority opposition because having some people in parliament doesn't really affect the networks of power that the CPP uses to maintain its hold on power throughout the country."

The rules in Cambodia's National Assembly are so strict that they make it difficult for minority party members to even raise concerns during parliamentary sessions.

Indeed, the CPP has commonly quashed opposition by co-opting anti-regime movements, granting their leaders political positions that lack any meaningful authority. Kurlantzick said, "It would be a typical cycle for there to be some moderation, or also co-option [...] offer [opposition leaders] incentives to give up opposition and join the government in some way."

In June 2017, however, commune elections—for local councils a level above village government—served as a wake-up call for Hun Sen. Despite the ruling party's repressive tactics, the CNRP won a significant number of seats at one of the most grassroots levels of government. Strangio explained in an email to *The Politic* that opposition presence in local positions poses a unique threat to Hun Sen. "The CPP has controlled the country through political networks that extend down to the village level... This is the bedrock of CPP control."

The CNRP victories reflected the long-held grievances of Cambodians who feel neglected and silenced by their government. Journalist Nathan Thompson told *The Politic*, "[The CNRP was] tapping into the general anger that people feel about the way the government operates in Cambodia. It's generally done through a system of cronies."

Unfair treatment under the law based on ties to government officials is commonplace.

"If there's ever any dispute between a connected person and a not-connected person, then the connected person tends to win—which is pretty serious when it comes to issues of land rights, because this is people's livelihood," Thompson said.

The public outrage did not bode well for Hun Sen, who had been expecting to win handily in the 2018 parliamentary vote. Since the commune elections, there have been reports of opposition members who won commune seats being followed and intimidated into joining the CPP.

But the CPP had reason to fear that its hold on the population was slipping even before this past year.

Parikh told *The Politic* in an email that when he stopped reporting for the *Daily* in April 2016, "There was a clear sense that—with commune and national elections on the two-year horizon—the ruling Cambodian People's Party was becoming increasingly

restive, paranoid, and repressive over dissenting voices."

Months before Parikh left Cambodia, Kem Ley, a prominent political commentator and government critic, "was assassinated in Phnom Penh under dubious circumstances."

Another factor motivating the current crackdown could be Cambodia's shifting geostrategy. Strangio argued that as China has emerged as a viable economic partner, "the government has been able to shrug off what is perceived to be an unwanted burden of Western demands about democracy."

In the past, the United States and other Western nations have attempted to rein in Hun Sen's repression and violence with threats to pull aid money. But now, those threats have less weight, since foreign aid from China accounted for nearly 36 percent of assistance received by Cambodia in 2016—almost four times the amount provided by the United States. While China is certainly not responsible for Hun Sen's three decades of repressing his people, it has provided the regime with hundreds of millions of dollars in financial backing as it deepens its crackdown on Cambodian civil society.

Though China may be a less outwardly demanding donor than the United States, the U.S. seems to have offered little more than lip service in its calls for democracy over the years.

Strangio told *The Politic* that "every foreign envoy that goes to Cambodia undergoes a similar sort of pattern."

When diplomats first arrive, they are impressed by the progress Cambodia seems to have made since the Khmer Rouge's brutal genocide. Initial meetings with Cambodian officials prove hopeful; the regime is adept at donor-speak. Over the course of their two- to four-year postings, Strangio said, envoys become disillusioned with the mirage of democracy.

"Power functions as a function of personal relationships and not... accountable and independent institutions," Strangio said.

Speaking on his experience living in Cambodia, Paviour told *The Politic* that in moments of political crisis, "Embassies, at best, put out some sort of statement... expressing grave concern... but at the end of the day, they're there to grease the wheels for business."

Similarly, Kurlantzick told *The Politic* that the EU is unlikely to follow through on a recent threat to revoke trade preferences, which are currently a boon for Cambodia's economy.

"They have to balance a desire for really holding Hun Sen accountable with the fact that the significant effect would probably make a lot of people who are relatively poor even poorer," he said.

Germany has suspended preferential treatment in issuing visas for private travel by Cambodian government members, but has held back on more sweeping sanctions.

So what can Cambodia's opposition expect? Recent jailings and past political violence have stoked fears among those who seek more democratic representation.

Sek told *The Politic* that his family and friends living in Cambodia "are very reluctant to answer questions related to politics" out of fear.

"This community has just woken up from a recent genocide in the '70s and '80s," he said. "So there's a significant amount of wounds and damage that... includes fear factors and suspicions."

It is possible that after Hun Sen secures a now-certain victory in the 2018 elections, he will decide it serves his political interests to let the CNRP reestablish itself under strict government control.

Kurlantzick said there may be "some sort of sham moderation of behavior before or after the election." Still, it is unlikely that the regime would allow the CNRP to enact meaningful change in Cambodia.

History has shown Hun Sen's tendency to fluctuate between repression and superficial relaxation, but Strangio told *The Politic*, "The baseline trend is moving towards more repression, and more permanent forms, a new status quo."

Paviour concurred.

"Generally these things tend to happen in waves... but this seems to be chugging along," he said. "I don't think even Hun Sen knows where it's going to end."

frisky business

cat cafés pounce on new markets

BY **LEAH SMITH**

THE CATS MAKE the rules here. Signs at the front prohibit patrons from feeding the residents or disturbing them with flash photography. An ominous placard reads "pet at your own risk." The space is cozy, stuffed with bean bag chairs and scratching posts—but cats have already claimed most of the available spots. The shelves are stocked with board games: Herding Cats, Feed the Kitty, and Cat-opoly.

Since Oakland Cat Town launched in 2014, cat cafes have cropped up across the U.S. New Haven's first cat cafe, Mew Haven, experimented with a pop-up for several weeks in November and December of 2017, and will open for good in the spring, at a date yet to be determined. The concept is straightforward: Most cafes charge five to ten dollars for an hour-long reservation, plus the cost of food and drink purchased by visitors.

Many cat cafe founders are patrons of existing cafes inspired to strike out on their own. Angela Pullo and her husband, the co-founders of Mew Haven, visited their first cat cafe in New York City in 2015, after their own cat died.

"We kept visiting cat cafes until we decided to open one," she said, "but we knew if we were going to do it, we couldn't do it in New York—the rent is astronomical."

The couple spent two years researching and then moved to New Haven in August 2017.

Cam Tucker, founder of Baltimore's Charm Kitty Cafe, first visited a cat cafe in Vienna, Austria. "It was unlike anything I had ever done," he said, "as a cat person, it was exciting."

A few years later he visited Crumbs and Whiskers, a large cat cafe in Washington, D.C., and was inspired to bring the idea to Baltimore. "I started to think, why can't Baltimore have our own cat cafe?" Tucker explained.

"Absolutely, no q

Amanda Bennett visited her first cat cafe on a visit to Montreal. "For years I joked with my best friend that it was my dream job, that when I won the lottery that's what I wanted to do," she said.

After working in design for an education technology company, she decided it was time for a change of pace. "I decided now is the time to do something more in line with my passion for animals, and my friend brought up the cat cafe again," she said. "I thought maybe this is the time." Bennett is in the process of setting up Neko no Cafe, Baltimore's second cat cafe.

If most cat cafe founders are former patrons, where did the idea begin? The idea of the cat cafe dates back to at least 1998, when Cat Flower Garden opened its doors in Taipei, Taiwan. Business was lackluster, until the novel combination of coffee and kittens began to draw media attention. But cat cafes did not truly pounce on the market until 2004, when the first opened in Japan. Since then,150 cat cafes have popped up across the country, with almost 60 in Tokyo alone. Apartment buildings in Japan often ban or restrict pets, and animal cafes—primarily cat cafes, but also rabbit, goat, and snake cafes—fill a void for those unable to keep a pet at home.

Cat cafes in countries with more relaxed pet restrictions, like the U.S., fill a different niche. Here the cafes are primarily filled with adoptable rather than permanent cats. Charm Kitty, Neko no Cafe, and Mew Haven are all partnered with local animal shelters, which provide the cats. While this arrangement can be difficult for shelters to pull off—it requires manpower and time from shelters already chronically underfunded and stretched to their limits—it can pay dividends in successful adoption rates.

"[Charm Kitty] has a quicker turnover rate than the shelter," Wendy Goldband, Marketing & PR Director at the Baltimore Humane Society, said. "Absolutely, no question the cat cafe is worth it. If another one pops up we'd be happy to join."

In the three and a half months that Charm Kitty has been open, the cafe has facilitated 41 adoptions. And when I visited Mew Haven on the last day of its pop-up opening, all the cats there had already been adopted.

At the cafes I visited, none of the visitors owned his or her own cats, but all had plans to adopt in the future. Some were actively considering the cats at the cafe; others wanted a chance to interact with the felines, to see how it felt. Carolyn Sacco '19, who visited Mew Haven during its pop-up stint, sees the cafe as a chance for a respite. "I feel like it's a really good stress-reliever for college students," she said. I really wanted to be around animals because we don't get to be around animals a lot at college," Sacco said.

For some people, the idea of a cat cafe gives them paws. But for others, like students, who cannot have their own pets at home, the cafes offer an hour's worth of interaction. But as I, the owner of two cats, learned, there is not much appeal to spending time with strange cats when you could be cuddling your own. This is the inherent contradiction of American cat cafes: They aim to increase adoption rates, but rid themselves of clients in the process. The business model counts on a steady stream of customers in search of feline companionship coming through the door.

While there are countless resources on how to start a cat cafe, just a short Google search away, challenges usually arise the form of local quirks. The founders of Charm Kitty, Neko no Cafe, and Mew Haven told me of the extensive research they conducted.

"I knew how to run a cat cafe," Pullo said. "What I needed to figure out was how to operate in Connecticut."

Cat cafes opening in the U.S. often face two major issues: zoning and health code concerns. Cat cafes operate in a grey area of zoning law, and are often classified as kennels or shelters. These designations are usually not permitted in a chosen location, usually in neighborhood storefronts, and owners are forced to

uestion the cat café is worth it."

apply for exemptions. Mew Haven has run into issues with its zoning status, which has yet to be fully resolved.

Bennett, owner of Neko no Cafe, was under the impression, based on reassurance from consultants, that her building was properly zoned for kennel use. But she later learned that advice was incorrect. Bennett plans to appeal the decision designating the cafe as a kennel, which usually refers to an establishment that holds more than three cats overnight, and argue that because she is a designated foster by the animal rescue, she has some ownership over the cats.

"There's no money being gained from the animals there," she said, "it's just going towards rent and basic bills."

Bennett is still waiting on both construction and the zoning appeal to proceed.

In the U.S., strict health code laws also create obstacles for those hoping to combine felines and food. In order to comply with the law, customers must buy their food and drink in one area and then take it into the cat area. These policies require a larger square footage, and often modifications to ensure that the food area and cat area are not directly connected. Paul Kowalski of the New Haven Health Department is skeptical of Mew Haven's plans.

"If someone wants to go from a licensed food establishment to a room occupied by pets or animals, they can do that, as long as the two are not directly connected," he said.

Mew Haven is not yet licensed to serve food, he said, and in order to be licensed will need to show it is in compliance with health code by sufficiently separating the food from the cats.

Cat cafes operate under a variety of business models: some have only a single Keurig machine, while others have baristas make drinks. Charm Kitty Cafe sells packaged cookies, cotton candy, and a few limited drinks. Neko no Cafe will be "a full-blown cafe, separated from the cats," Bennett said. "People can come in and get food and drink, and espressos, and then if they want they can go see the cats." Bennett is partnering with a local bakery to provide food. Mew Haven will follow a similar approach, with food made off site by New Haven bakeries, and a barista on site to make tea and coffee. Other cat cafes have both food and drinks delivered hourly to their location.

A recent Wall Street Journal article chronicled struggles faced by cat cafes across the country: escaping cats, scratched customers, and even potential anti-feline vandalism. But all the owners I interviewed said that business was good—Tucker was interviewed but not quoted in the Journal article, which he criticized as bad press for the trend. Mew Haven's pop-up was successful, with weekends fully booked and five or six other customers there when I visited on a Wednesday.

Charm Kitty has done solid business, too, with so much demand when it opened in September 2017 that it had to turn people away. "Things have evened out now, and we've found our spot," Tucker said.

And while Neko no Cafe will be the second cat cafe opening in Baltimore in under a year, just about a mile up the road from Charm Kitty, Bennett is confident she will profit from the trend's popularity. Based on revenue projections, it should be under a year until the business is in the black. "The response I've gotten in the neighborhood has been overwhelmingly positive about having another cat cafe," Bennett said.

For feline-focused establishments, this is only the first of nine lives. Bennett is looking into organizing therapy groups once Neko no Cafe launches. And Charm Kitty is planning expansion this year, building up a Charm Kitty brand and merchandise. Tucker has introduced events like cat yoga, movie nights, and a sold out cat photography class.

"We are trying to challenge the idea of what can and cannot happen in the Charm Kitty space," he said. "It's more of a cat creative space."

UP, UP, AND AWAY

BY **EMILY XU**

Alphabet's latest moonshot seeks to provide internet through balloons

Project Loon is the latest endeavor to come out of X, the innovation branch of Google's parent company Alphabet. It is a system of high-altitude balloons that beam internet to those below. The team at X hopes that Project Loon will provide a solution to lack of internet access in rural and remote areas worldwide.

HOW IT WORKS

THE TEAM HAS already launched hundreds of balloons into the sky, collectively flying over 25 million kilometers. Each tennis court-size balloon is lifted with helium to an altitude of around 20 kilometers—twice the height reached by commercial airplanes. The payload of each balloon includes solar-powered technology that emits high-speed cellular internet to mobile devices.

GONE WITH THE WIND

TO DECREASE WEIGHT, the balloons depend on naturally-occuring wind for locomotion instead of motors.

In the stratosphere, wind streams are layered, and each layer corresponds to a specific speed and direction. A computer program maps each balloon's route by choosing the right wind streams to lead the balloon to its target location. The system even allows a cluster of balloons to coordinate their flight.

STAYING AFLOAT

TO LOWER COSTS, engineers had to maximize the flight time of each balloon. The balloons—made of thin sheets of polyethylene plastic—can be easily pierced with a fingernail, so any stray dirt particles could create a microscopic hole and bring a balloon down in less than two weeks.

A special team was formed to come up with creative solutions to this problem. Its recommendations have included changes to the balloon design, new auto-launchers to release the balloons, and fluffier socks for the workers who step on the balloons during construction. Once these modifications were implemented, the balloons have stayed afloat for up to 190 days.

CAN LOON CONNECT THE WORLD?

THE INTERNET PLAYS a crucial role in most aspects of modern life, but only 51 percent of the world's population can access it. In Africa and Asia, those rates are only 32 percent and 47 percent. Furthermore, there are disparities in internet access between developing and developed nations, and between urban and rural areas.

These disparities are driven mainly by the high cost of infrastructure required to reach remote areas. Even if a company decides to install the costly wires necessary to provide land-based internet to a remote locale, it will find it hard to make a profit due to the low density of customers.

"In places that are hard to put down wires, Project Loon is an alternative that is relatively efficient over short distances," said Richard Bennett, who co-invented Ethernet, a computer networking technology, in an interview with *The Politic*.

ONE OF MANY

X'S PROJECT LOON is by no means Silicon Valley's only attempt to connect the world at an affordable price. Facebook's Aquila aims to bring internet connectivity to remote areas through solar-powered drones. SpaceX plans to deploy a system of satellites that will beam broadband internet to every corner of the earth. Additionally, Microsoft has started the Airband Initiative, providing grants for telecommunications startups around the globe and promoting new technologies such as TV white space, which takes advantage of unused spectrum to deliver broadband.

NOT SO FAST?

QUESTIONS REMAIN about potential conflicts of interest and the true motivations behind the "charitable" actions of large technology companies. In 2015, Facebook launched Internet.org, a free internet platform, in India. It was immediately mired in controversy: The platform allowed access to a limited number of websites, and Facebook was the only social media available to users. Eventually, the service was banned for violating net neutrality laws.

Other concerns have been voiced about the lack of regulations to protect users from corporate interests. Ross Tapsell, a professor at the Australian National University, echoed these criticisms in an interview with *The Politic*.

"There is actually a lot to question the role of private companies in terms of internet development," he said. "We do need to question the motivations of these companies in the way that they make their companies ubiquitous in terms of internet usage, and [...] how they might manipulate the data and [sell it] for various purposes. The role of companies is not as altruistic as they make it out [to be]."

A TEST FOR LOON?

WHEN HURRICANE Maria barrelled through Puerto Rico and millions were left without access to the internet, Alphabet leapt to provide aid. Just two and a half weeks after Maria's landfall in September 2017, the Federal Communications Commission announced it would allow Project Loon to be deployed to the island.

Chris Hillis, the co-founder of the non-profit Information Technology Disaster Resource Center, stressed the importance of internet access to disaster survivors in an interview with *The Politic*. "It's a mental health issue—it is very important for them to reach out to their families," he said. "But the biggest thing is that they can fill out their online assistance forms through FEMA."

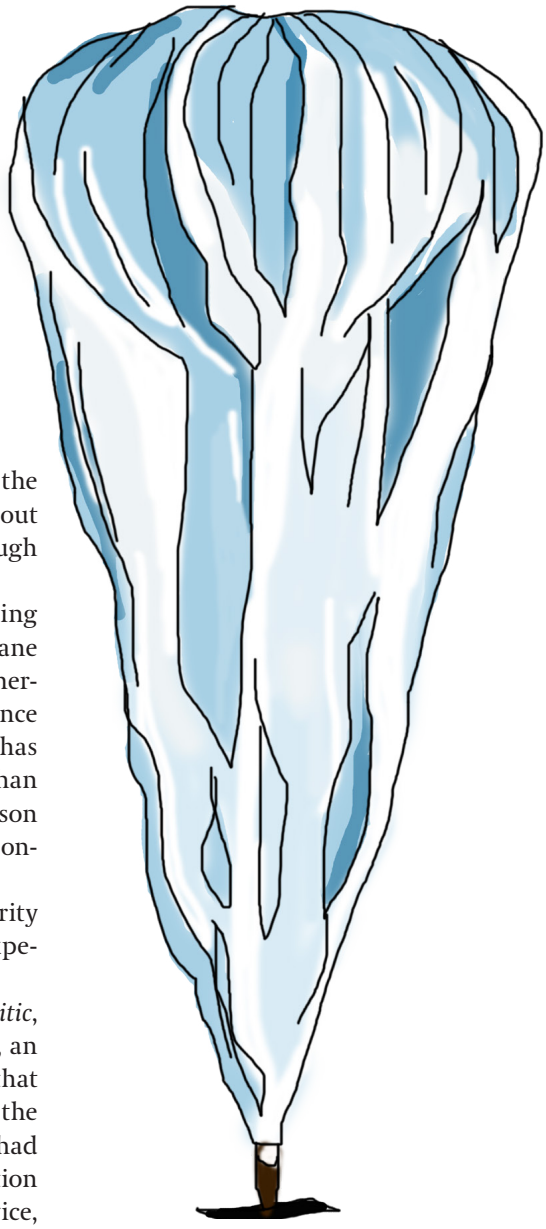
"Project Loon has been providing emergency connectivity in hurricane devastated Puerto Rico in partnership with AT&T and T-Mobile. Since turning on service, Project Loon has delivered connectivity to more than 150K people," said X spokesperson Libby Leahy, in a written correspondence with *The Politic*.

But there seems to be a disparity between official reports and the experiences of Puerto Ricans.

In an interview with *The Politic*, Eliut Flores, an executive at Intech, an IT company based in San Juan, said that he was "deeply disappointed" by the technology because the balloons had trouble maintaining their position in order to deliver continuous service, and he never received information on how to access the cellular service. He was not the only one let down.

"I don't think there was a real effect. At the beginning, many people thought that it was going to save the rural areas so that they could get internet connection, but that myth got busted really fast," explained Carlos Meléndez, the Chief Operating Officer of Wovenware, an artificial intelligence company also located in San Juan.

Still, most remain optimistic about the potential long-term benefits of innovations like Loon. Flores, for example, was not convinced that balloons are the answer to Puerto Rico's connectivity issues. But he has hope that the next moonshot idea to come out of the technology industry will be the one that finally takes off.



"THE ROLE OF COMPANIES IS NOT AS ALTRUISTIC AS THEY MAKE IT OUT [TO BE]"

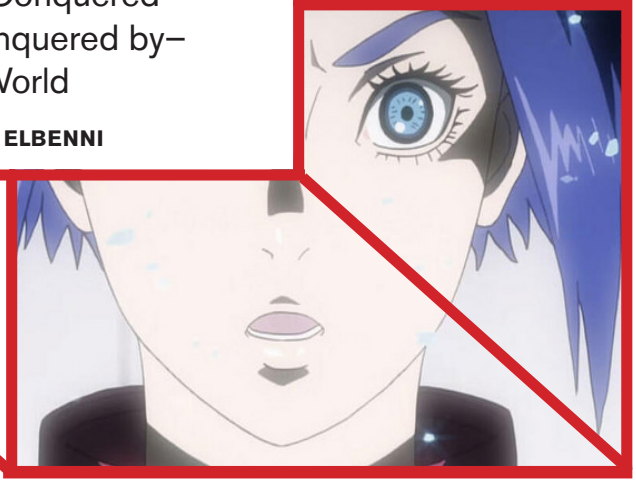




Animating Alternatives

How Anime Conquered– And Was Conquered by– The World

BY **AHMED ELBENNI**



SETH JACOBOWITZ, associate Yale professor of East Asian Languages and Literature, was not expecting much of a turnout for his newest class, EALL 357: Anime and the Posthuman. Class sizes in his department typically range from five to ten students, and anime, traditionally defined as "Japanese animation," seemed too niche a subject to attract a large audience. But once he held the first class session in William Harkness Hall, Jacobowitz quickly discovered that he had miscalculated.

"Professor Jacobowitz was very surprised at how many people showed up," recalled Robert Calebresi '18. "We were originally in a seminar-size classroom, and 50 people were just stuffed in there and pouring out into the hallway, and he's like, 'Ok, we're moving.'"

Calebresi, who is president of the Yale Anime Society, is one of the nearly 50 students taking EALL 357 this spring. He's in the company of students with interests as diverse as the animations they're studying: humanities, computer science, music. They are unified only by a shared fascination with anime, which until recently might have been considered "niche" in the West. For Jacobowitz, the popularity of such a class would have been inconceivable in the 90s, when he was an undergraduate at Columbia University.

While anime is a long way from attaining the mainstream exposure of comic-book blockbusters like *The Avengers* or the cultural prestige of HBO series *Game of Thrones*, it has grown to unprecedented proportions in the global consciousness. Hollywood has begun producing live-action adaptations of anime classics, including a controversial adaptation of *Ghost in the Shell* last year starring Scarlett Johansson. Makoto Shinkai's *Your Name*, a fantasy romance film, enjoyed a limited theater release worldwide and shattered box office records to become the highest-grossing anime film of all time. YouTube anime bloggers like Digibro and Gigguk have built careers by producing exclusively anime-based videos. Meanwhile, Netflix has begun not only streaming anime in 190 countries, but producing it. The studio has already collaborated with Japanese director Masaaki Yuasa to release an original anime series, *Devilman Crybaby,* and has bought exclusive streaming rights to Kyoto Animation's latest release, *Violet Evergarden.*

Violet Evergarden, a series about a soldier attempting to reintegrate into civilian society, is one of the shows that the Yale Anime Society watches weekly. Similar clubs have sprung up on college and high school campuses across the U.S. Many of YAS's regulars are enrolled in Jacobowitz's anime course.

For Calebresi, who has always been "very visually-minded," anime has deepened his appreciation for film and animation.

"I wrote an essay on *Ghost in the Shell* for a film course that I was taking

last year, and to me it was just like any other film, it just happens to be animated," said Calebresi. "People seem to separate anime from other mediums when it really shouldn't be. I find many anime movies to be just as good if not better than live-action films."

Other fans are attracted to anime's versatility. It can tell stories about almost anything, from volleyball underdogs to space bounty hunters. Others think anime offers more options for meaningful storytelling than Western cartoons do. Still others enjoy witnessing the evolution of anime as a medium, since the form is young enough that the lineages of its artists are easily traceable.

"It's a very incestuous production environment," said Gene Yoon '17, a former YAS member. "It's really easy to sort of see where [artists] are drawing their influences, especially since a lot of anime producers are themselves anime fans, especially in this era. It's a very intimate feeling. It's like fans producing for other fans."

It is perhaps fitting that YAS's members watch *Violet Evergarden,* a television series based on the winning contest submission of a fellow anime fan. From its conception, anime has been something of a large fan project, in terms of the people who produce it and consume it. That the number of anime fans outside of Japan has grown far greater than those inside it, and that those fans continue to participate in the proliferation, interpretation, and now even production of anime, challenges the very idea of what "anime" can be, and suggests tantalizing possibilities for what it might become.

ANIME'S JOURNEY TO mainstream acceptance has been long and difficult, domestically and globally. Although anime (and manga, the Japanese comics that serve as much of its source material) is a crucial cultural export from Japan, even there it has not existed without controversy.

While many international fans would refer to any Japanese animation as "anime," some animators in Japan have disputed the term's applicability to their work. According to Jacobowitz, filmmakers like Hayao Miyazaki (*Spirited Away*) and Mamoru Oshii (*Ghost in the Shell*), the sort of auteurs who aspire to international film awards, dismiss anime as "lowbrow, mass-market garbage" and therefore do not refer to their own animated features as such. The societal stigma from which anime suffers in Japan and elsewhere has not been helped by the "hentai" (anime porn) industry, nor by a popular perception that "otaku" (hardcore fans) are obsessive, reclusive failures who could not complete the transition to adulthood.

Despite these challenges, Jacobowitz said, animation is now "completely integrated into Japan's information society." In Japan, animated characters instruct subway riders on proper etiquette, help deliver public service announcements, and decorate convenience store snacks. According to Young Yi, a doctoral student and teaching fellow for Jacobowitz's course, anime has become a ubiquitous aspect of Japanese popular culture, "from the bank explanation of how to use an ATM to warning posters about sexual abusers."

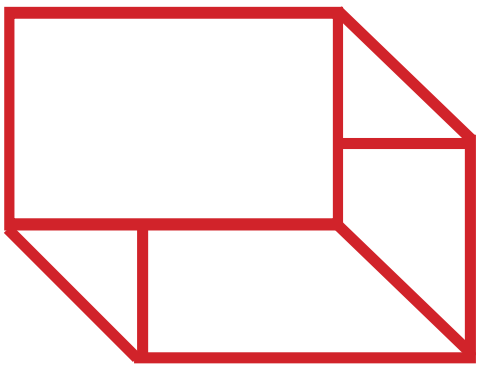
"Even if you are not technically a fan of anime, just by going into a convenience store or taking a train, [you're] automatically brought into the discourses of anime," Yi told *The Politic*. "Ubiquity and the mundane become two key vectors of consuming or partaking in anime whether you want to or not."

Anime in Japan has become so mainstream that in recent years, the Japanese government has sought to leverage anime's cross-cultural appeal to improve its global reputation, attract international students, and bolster its creative industries. Dubbed "Cool Japan," this public relations strategy is best understood as the Japanese government's conscious manipulation of the country's "soft power" to political and economic ends. But such externally focused efforts are not principally responsible for anime's remarkable popularity beyond Japan's borders.

"To understand how anime became a global phenomenon, you have to look beyond the borders of animation production," said Ian Condry, professor of Japanese cultural studies at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology in an interview with *The Politic*. He noted a "synergy" between manga, anime, toy companies, and fan activities, "from fan convention to fanmade works that are online."

Anime's global takeover was grassroots. The most important transmitters of anime were not animation companies or national governments, but something more ordinary: enthusiastic fans eager to share their hobby. The way Condry sees it, "the role of fans and fan activity tends to be underplayed in understanding anime and animation business."

IN JACOBOWITZ'S undergraduate days, back in the 1990s, fans recorded original Japanese anime broadcasts, added translatory subtitles, and illegally distributed the tapes to other fans. The dawn of the internet only accelerated and amplified the process. Hundreds of "fansubbing" groups digitized Japanese broadcasts, translated them, and shared them online as downloadable torrent files. Additionally, online forums gave fans a space



> "The role of fans and fan activity tends to be underplayed in understanding anime and animation business."

to discuss their idiosyncratic hobby, even if they lived across the world from one another.

The impact of such new technologies was profound: They enabled cross-cultural exchange by fostering a cohesive anime community unhindered by geographic barriers; and they expanded access to anime and thus reached millions of potential new fans. This new anime subculture, however, was built on egregious violations of copyright laws. While some concerns over fan-subbing's economic impact on domestic and international anime sales might be warranted, Condry finds much of the negative rhetoric on piracy overblown.

"I think piracy is complicated," Condry said. "But I [also] think it's a mistake to demonize people as pirates without also recognizing some of the positive things that can come out of sharing media online. If it's me, if the choice is between somebody paying for it or somebody not seeing what I made, I'd much rather have somebody see what I made, even if they didn't pay for it. I'd rather be paid [but] I think it's more damaging if no one is ever going to see my work because it's so expensive."

Just as piracy built a market for Hollywood films in China, so too has it built a market for anime around the globe. Even with the recent explosion of legal streaming services like Crunchyroll, illegal anime streaming sites receive more global traffic than giants like Hulu and IGN. Piracy's enduring popularity continues to expand the international market and fandom, into which megacorporations like Netflix are now investing.

The international anime fandom expresses its passion both on- and offline. Fan-run anime conventions have occupied a central place in Western anime subculture since 1991, serving as massive gatherings where anime fans share merchandise, dress as favorite characters, and meet industry insiders. Anime Expo, the largest anime and manga convention in the U.S., attracted over 100,000 attendees last year. Fans also write fanfiction, circulate fan art, and produce abridged parodies of popular series.

The phenomenon of "fans producing for other fans," to put it in Yoon's words, reached new levels in 2016, when international anime fans discovered that they could create not just anime-based works but "official" anime itself. American DJ Porter Robinson and French DJ Madeon collaborated with Japanese studio A-1 Pictures to produce an animated music video for their original song "Shelter." Robinson wrote the story, which centers on a 17-year-old girl named Rin as she navigates life in a futuristic simulation. *Shelter*'s existence demonstrated that it was not only Japanese anime fans who might one day have a chance to produce "official" anime; overseas fans had a shot as well.

But though massively popular (the original video has amassed more than 28 million views on YouTube), *Shelter* immediately resurrected the age-old question as to what, exactly, counts as an anime. The moderators of r/anime, one of the largest anime forums online, deleted posts discussing the music video because they believed it did not comport with their definition of anime as "an animated series, produced and aired in Japan, intended for a Japanese audience." Critics defended *Shelter* by pointing to its anime aesthetic, production by a Japanese animation studio, and debut in Tokyo. The controversy crystallized an important debate: In an age of globalization, can "anime" retain its Japanese exclusivity?

> As anime flows into the cultural mainstream, it is likely to become something else.

THE QUESTION OF WHETHER or not anime can remain exclusively Japanese might be fundamentally flawed, Jacobowitz suggests, because it fails to differentiate between "anime" as a product and anime as a production. Anime studios have been outsourcing animation to China and Korea for years, meaning that much of what fans call "anime" is not even produced in Japan and often bears the fingerprints of non-Japanese animators.





More importantly, Japanese animators have long drawn inspiration from non-Japanese sources. Osamu Tezuka, the so-called "god of manga," was an avid fan of Walt Disney as a child. He eventually pioneered an aesthetic—bold lines, big heads, and large eyes—first developed by Disney, and his comics brim with overt visual references to characters like Mickey Mouse. Tezuka's influence on the Japanese animation industry meant that his visual style would become synonymous with that of anime and manga, entrenching as essentially Japanese what had begun as American.

"The idea that Japanese animation has always been somehow intrinsically unique is somewhat misleading," said Jacobowitz. "It does have a distinctive look—at times—but there are all kinds of constant references to American pop culture, whether it be Star Wars, or the Blade Runner, or Miami Vice, or the Terminator. In a certain sense, there has never been a hermetically sealed, essentially Japanese art form that is just unique to Japan."

Not that the cultural exchange has been a one-way street. The transfer came full circle in 1994, when Disney released *The Lion King,* which drew heavily on Tezuka's 1960s animated television series *Kimba the White Lion*. Meanwhile, the visual and narrative aesthetics of Hayao Miyazaki's films and other touchstones of Japanese animation heavily influenced popular American shows like *Avatar: The Last Airbender* and *Samurai Jack.*

As cultural and economic globalization erode the national boundaries of the animation production landscape, the international understanding of the term "anime" as singularly Japanese appears destined to undergo fundamental redefinition.

"We can expect to see convergence," said Jacobowitz. "As people all over the world are consuming the same things, or almost the same things, they also adopt [a] similar degree of homogeneity in their aesthetic…That seems to be where anime is likely to head."

For a longtime fan like Yoon, anime's booming global popularity and gradual (but ongoing) transition from niche subculture to global culture is bittersweet. He's happy to see more people share his passion, and he believes that anime's international success is economically healthy for an industry that has struggled domestically in recent years. But he also recognizes that Jacobowitz is correct: As anime flows into the cultural mainstream, it is likely to become something else.

"I am actually really happy with how things are currently; it doesn't really bother me that it's a niche interest," said Yoon. "You have those cross-cultural hits that I very much enjoy. But I think I come to anime for what it can offer that other mediums can't, and to reach a broader audience it would have to become like other types of existing media—and I think we'd be losing something there."

CRIMMIGRATION

BY LILY MOORE-EISSENBERG

HOW MISLEADING STATISTICS WRITE CRIME INTO IDENTITY

PRESIDENT DONALD TRUMP is fond of walls, cops, and anecdotes. But he's savvy enough to like statistics, too—as long as they tell the right story.

"When you cook the books you shouldn't pretend to be surprised by the results," Tom Jawetz, the vice president for Immigration Policy at American Progress, a liberal think tank in Washington, D.C., told The *New York Times* in December. He was referring to the Alien Incarceration Report—a quarterly report on incarceration rates of immigrants, created by an executive order that Trump signed in January 2017.

According to the report, in the fiscal year 2017, one-fifth of federal prison inmates were foreign-born. Of those confirmed to be "aliens," meaning non-citizens, over 90 percent were unlawfully present.

"Report reveals 92 percent of foreign nationals in federal prisons are illegal immigrants," announced *Fox News* on December 21, 2017, the day the administration released the findings. A *Breitbart* headline reported the statistic as "nearly 95 percent."

In the weeks that followed publication, right-wing media outlets and members of the Trump Administration used the statistics to argue that immigrants were dangerous criminals. But such reasoning misses the fact that many immigrants are incarcerated for immigration offenses, such as unlawfully entering or remaining in the U.S., which do not threaten public safety. In the early 2000s, immigration offenses accounted for 28 percent of federal arrests, according to the Pew Research Center. Today, the Center reported, the number is closer to 50 percent.

In fact, the argument is tautological: The reason for the high immigrant incarceration rate is that undocumented immigrants are incarcerated for being undocumented immigrants. Citing the high rate as proof that undocumented immigrants are more dangerous than citizens is illogical for two reasons: One, immigration offenses are not dangerous, and two, citizens—by definition—cannot commit the offenses that make up about half of federal arrests.

High immigrant incarceration is a product of developments in the U.S. law enforcement and justice systems over the past three decades. Immigration law and criminal law have become increasingly enmeshed, as Stanford law professor David Sklansky argues in his 2012 article, "Crime, Immigration, and Ad hoc Instrumentalism." Sklansky describes "routine incarceration" as a "concrete practice that immigration law has imported from criminal law." He calls the hybrid law "crimmigration."

Far from an exercise in "transparency"—the administration's stated reason for collecting the data—the Alien Incarceration Report is a recent case study in a centuries-old American tradition: the misuse of statistics to ascribe criminality to marginalized groups.

Over a century ago, Frederick L. Hoffman—a then-renowned American statistician—analyzed crime and incarceration data and concluded that black Americans were morally and biologically inferior to white Americans.

In his 2010 book, "Condemnation of Blackness," Khalil Gibran Muhammad describes a practice in 19th-century American statistics of "writing crime into race." He discusses Hoffman's pioneering statistical studies of black crime and incarceration rates. From the high rates that he found, Hoffman concluded that black Americans were morally and biologically inferior to white Americans.

To be sure, the comparison between Hoffman's studies and the Alien Incarceration Report is imperfect. The criminalization of blackness in the U.S. has taken the form of vagrancy laws, false accusations, and differential treatment by the authorities, including police and judges. The problem with Hoffman's account was that he attributed high black crime rates to a supposedly innate criminality, when social and economic forces—such as racism, poor education, poor health care, poverty, and malnutrition—were the real culprits.

But, as Sklansky discusses in his article, studies have shown that immigrant populations today do not have higher violent crime rates than the general population. The statistical work behind the Alien Incarceration Report falls short in a fairly simple way: It disregards easily quantified factors, like how many incarcerated immigrants have committed crimes that only non-citizens can commit, such as unlawful presence, or misdemeanors less likely to be discovered or prosecuted if the offender were a citizen.

Still, Hoffman's work and the report have clear parallels. Behind the inscription of crime into marginalized groups is the idea that exposing identity-based criminality is necessary for the well-being of American citizens. (That is, the chosen American citizens—white Americans in Hoffman's case and, often, in the case of immigration, since racist sentiment often accompanies anti-immigrant sentiment.)

"Beginning with Hoffman," Muhammad writes, many 19th-century white race-relations writers "wanted their fellow Americans to see the indisputable evidence of black criminality as the key to binding the nation together to keep the 'negro' in his place."

Marginalizing black Americans for the sake of national unity is reminiscent of the rhetoric surrounding the "alien incarceration" statistics, which stressed imagined threats posed by immigrants to the nation. In both cases, the minority population was disproportionately incarcerated, and the high rates of incarceration were interpreted as indicative of an innate tendency toward higher criminality. Both accounts were alarmist, ignoring systemic reasons for the incarceration rates and instead spreading fears among Americans that natural criminals were in their midst.

"The simple fact is that any offense committed by a criminal alien is ultimately preventable," Attorney General Jeff Sessions said in response to the publication of the Alien Incarceration Report. "One victim is too many."

Sessions' emphasis on victims is striking, since immigration offenses, which are responsible for the disproportionately high immigrant incarceration rate, are victimless. Secretary of Homeland Security Kirstjen Nielsen also pushed the Trump Administration's immigration agenda in her statement.

"While the administration is working diligently to remove dangerous criminal aliens from our streets, this report highlights the fact that more must be done," Nielsen said.

Articles responding to the report's publication in right-wing media—like the ones published on *Fox News* and *Breitbart*, both of which quoted parts from Sessions and Nielsen's statements—illuminate the ways in which "alien incarceration" statistics are being used to write crime into immigration.

The authors of the articles and the members of the administration assume that there is no categorical dif-



ference between immigration offenses and traditionally criminal crimes, like those connected to drugs, gangs, theft, and violence. Increasingly, that assumption is indeed aligned with the way law enforcement works in the U.S. But it is not a result or objective reflection of the way American law is changing. Rather, it is part of a positive feedback loop between the growth of "crimmigration law" and the conflation of immigration offenses and violent crime in public discourse.

Anti-immigrant sentiment is part of the loop, too. Implicit in the statement, "immigration is criminal"—which, operationally in the U.S. today, approaches the truth—is the statement, "immigrants are criminals."

The shift toward "crimmigration law" began in earnest in the 1990s. A chart in Sklansky's article shows that the average daily population in immigration detention from 1994 to 2009 increased from 6,800 to 33,800 detainees over the 15-year span. According to Sklansky, who calls the system of detention facilities "a parallel prison system," immigration centers were the first American private prisons.

Though not all of these centers are included in the Alien Incarceration Report—an omission criticized by the administration's opponents—the trend is represented in the facilities that were included. The Federal Bureau of Prisons and U.S. Marshals Service both hold large populations of immigrants, as do state prisons and local detention centers. Immigration offenses account for the presence of 7.2 percent of inmates under the Bureau's jurisdiction. Under the U.S. Marshals Service, whose historic function is detainment, the "fastest-growing population…by far, is immigration offenders," according to a *Quartz Media* investigation from June 2017.

"The increase accelerated in the mid-2000s, when the federal government was rapidly expanding the practice of charging people detained entering the country with misdemeanors, and those who reentered with felonies," the *Quartz* article states.

When crime is written into identity, the stakes are high. The practical implication of inscription is disappearance—of undocumented immigrants by deportation and stricter immigration control, and of black Americans by mass incarceration.

Prophetically, the executive order that created the report predicted the conclusions that would be drawn from the data. Sanctuary jurisdictions, the order stated, "have caused immeasurable harm to the American people and to the very fabric of our Republic." (By sanctuary jurisdictions, the order was referring to cities that do not comply with the federal mandate to disclose information with the government about immigrants' citizenship or legal status.)

The creation of the Alien Incarceration Report was an exercise in induction from incomplete data. It was an attempt to confirm, through pseudo-scientific means, what the administration had already stated as truth, and to provide statistical support for an ideological conclusion.

Crime is also still being written into race. The rhetoric surrounding "law-and-order politics," as journalists and scholars have noted, has taken on a racial subtext. The superpredator theory of the 1990s was an alarmist (and ultimately debunked) account of a rising cohort of violent American youths—the majority black—who supposedly posed a dire threat to public safety.

The use of statistics to write crime into race is an older American tradition than the writing of crime into immigration. The inscriptions are distinct—but they are also mutually informative.

"Many white race-relations writers hoped to blaze a research trail to solve the Negro Problem by writing crime into race," Muhammad writes. "In the process, they also hoped to save the nation by using black criminality as a rhetorical bridge to heal deep sectional divisions and distrust rooted in the postbellum era. These writers saw vital racial statistics as a pathway to certainty and serenity."

But attempts to disappear black Americans did not foster unity. They sowed divisions not yet mended after more than one hundred years.

"The simple fact is that any offense committed by a criminal alien is ultimately preventable"
- Attorney General Jeff Sessions



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Pride and Politics: Gibraltar's Battle with Brexit

BY **JAMES LEWIS '20**

While the streets of London were bustling with last minute electioneering before the vote on whether to remain part of the EU, 1,000 miles away, a very different scene was unfolding. On Gibraltar, the two and a half square mile island off the Southern coast of Spain, the same vote was taking place, but with very different results. James Lewis '20 investigates the impact of Brexit on the people of Gibraltar.

Take a Vet Fishing

BY **EMILY JI '21**

When veterans return home to Connecticut, they seek out support in different ways. A group in Branford, Connecticut, offers a day fishing. Emily Ji '21 profiles Take a Vet Fishing, an organization that aims to create an unorthodox and relaxing environment for veterans.

#MeToo in Connecticut: The Long Wharf Theater Faces Claims of Sexual Assault

BY **SELENA CHO '20**

In January, news broke of sexual harassment and assault in the Long Wharf Theater, several miles away from Yale. How does this particular instance of abuse in a creative community reflect broader structural problems? How has New Haven responded? Selena Cho '20 reports.

Restorative Justice: Attempting to Find Answers after Domestic Abuse

BY **AYLA KHAN '21**

More than twenty years after Attiya Khan, now 40 years old, escaped from her abusive relationship, she decided to revisit her trauma through film. In her documentary "A Better Man," Khan sits down with her former abuser, Steve, in the presence of a therapist, to talk through her experiences. Ayla Khan '21 analyzes the film to better understand one victim's journey to healing and the process of Restorative Justice.

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